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TRAFFICKING ATTEMPT
163 children rescued in M.P., eight men held

NEWS » PAGE 10

NEED FOR CARE
Delimitation is the issue, not women's reservation: Sonia
"The exercise will be an assault on the Constitution"

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8

'APPROPRIATE TIMING'
Nepal PM to visit India soon, says FM Khanal

WORLD » PAGE 16

FIRING AGAIN
Salt and Patidar help RCB get back on track

SPORT » PAGE 17

Electorate falls by 10.2% in nine States, three U.T.s

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Among the nine States and three Union Territories that undertook the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in the second phase, Uttar Pradesh has recorded the highest net deletion of voters in absolute numbers at 2.04 crore, followed by West Bengal at 83.86 lakh.

In percentage terms, the Andaman and Nicobar Islands had the highest net deletion at 16.6%. Lakshadweep recorded the lowest deletion, both in absolute numbers (181) and percentage terms (0.3%).

According to data shared by Election Commission of India (EC) sources, as many as 67 lakh deceased voters and 1.28 crore duplicate voters were removed in this phase, which was announced on October 27 last year. It identified 1.34 crore non-existent voters and 3.15 crore voters who had migrated. The consolidated electoral rolls of the nine States and three Union Territories saw a reduction of 10.2%, bringing the number of active voters down to 45.81 crore from more than 50.99 crore before the revision exercise.

CONTINUED ON
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Iran, U.S. blame each other as talks end without a deal

Talks collapsed after Iran's refusal to commit to abandoning its path to a nuclear weapon, says U.S. after the 21-hour-long talks in Pakistan; Iran blames 'U.S. overreach' for breakdown of dialogue

Associated Press
ISLAMABAD

The United States and Iran ended face-to-face talks in Pakistan on Sunday without an agreement, each side keeping the onus on the other without narrowing their differences and leaving a fragile two-week ceasefire in the war in West Asia in doubt.

U.S. officials said the talks collapsed over Iran's refusal to commit to abandoning the path to a nuclear weapon, while Iranian officials blamed the "U.S. overreach" for the breakdown of the talks without mentioning specific sticking points.

Neither side indicated what will happen after the truce expires on April 22. Pakistani Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar said his country

Hanging in the balance

The breakdown of talks leaves doubt over the future of the two-week ceasefire in the war in West Asia



We need to see an affirmative commitment that they [Iran] will not seek a nuclear weapon
J.D. VANCE, U.S. Vice-President

It is time for the U.S. to decide whether it can gain our trust or not — **MOHAMMAD BAGHER GHALIBAF**, Iran Speaker

Winding up: Pakistan officials escort U.S. delegation leaving after the talks on Sunday. AFP

will try to facilitate a new dialogue in the coming days.

"We need to see an affirmative commitment that they will not seek a nuclear weapon, and they will not seek the tools that would enable them to quickly achieve a nuclear weapon," U.S. Vice-President

J.D. Vance said after the 21-hour talks. Iran's Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, who led the Iran delegation, said it was time for the U.S. "to decide whether it can gain our trust or not".

CONTINUED ON
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Trump threatens blockade of Strait of Hormuz

ISLAMABAD/WASHINGTON
U.S. President Donald Trump on Sunday said the U.S. Navy would "immediately" begin a blockade of the Strait of Hormuz. » PAGE 16

NEARBY



T.N. in front in various metrics, says CM Stalin

RAMANATHAPURAM
DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday asserted that Tamil Nadu has been outperforming other States in all major metrics of development. » PAGE 4

Alliances only for polls, ideology is permanent: EPS

NAGAPATTINAM
Alliances were only for elections, whereas ideology was permanent, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said on Sunday. » PAGE 4

EDUCATIONPLUS » PAGE 6,7&19

Asha Bhosle, versatile singer, dies in Mumbai

Chinmay Gaiikwad
MUMBAI

Legendary playback singer Asha Bhosle died in Mumbai on Sunday. She was 92.

The singer was admitted to the Breach Candy Hospital on Saturday evening with exhaustion and a chest infection. Hospital officials said the cause of death was multi-organ failure following a cardiac arrest.

Her son, Anand Bhosle, confirmed the news outside the hospital. He said



ASHA BHOSLE (1933-2026)

those who wish to pay their last respects may visit her residence on Monday at 11 a.m. Her last rites will

be performed at Shivaji Park at 4 p.m, with full state honours.

Ms. Bhosle, who record-

ed nearly 12,000 songs in over 20 languages throughout a career spanning decades, is widely considered one of the most versatile voices in Indian music.

Part of heritage

Condoling the death of the singer, President Droupadi Murmu said it had created a huge void in the world of music. "She led her life on her own terms as an artist and as an individual. With her melodious and timeless voice, she enriched In-

dian music for decades," the President said.

Describing her as one of the most famous and versatile voices, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said he was deeply saddened by her passing. Her musical journey enriched the country's cultural heritage and touched the hearts of millions across the world, Mr. Modi said.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 10
VOICE OF MODERN INDIA
» PAGE 12

Lord, all our success is because of what You have done.
Isaiah 26:12

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12 fishermen from T.N., Karaikal held by Sri Lankan Navy

The Hindu Bureau
KARAIKAL

A total of 12 fishermen, including five from Tamil Nadu, were apprehended by the Sri Lankan Navy on Saturday night for allegedly crossing the International Maritime Boundary Line (IMBL), sources said.

The fishermen had ventured into the sea in a mechanised boat, owned by Veeravel of Tsunami Nagar at Kilinjalmadu in Karaikal district, from the Karaikal fishing harbour around 10 a.m. on April 10. While they were fishing about 60 nautical miles off Karaikal, the boat was intercepted by the Sri Lankan Navy around 9 p.m. on April 11, and all 12 fishermen on board were taken into custody.

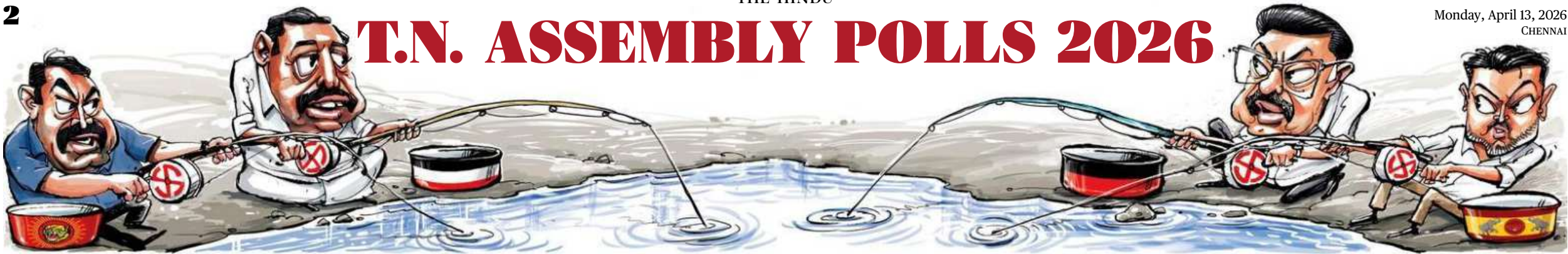
Among those detained were four fishermen from Mayiladuthurai district, one from Nagapattinam district, and seven from Karaikal district.



The fishermen had ventured into the sea from the Karaikal harbour on April 10.

The detained fishermen were identified as Tamilvanan, 42, of Nagapattinam; Karthik, 32, Vignesh, 21, Veerendrarajan, 33, and Jayaveeran, 28, of Mayiladuthurai district; and Arulselvan, 28, Sanjay, 30, Pradeep, 29, Viman, 24, Madhan, 26, Nishwanthan, 20, and Saminathan, 20, of Karaikal district.

The Sri Lankan authorities reportedly took them to the Kankesanthurai harbour, the sources added.



Less enthusiastic: In the 2021 Assembly election, about 61.48% of Chennai's electorate turned out, while the State average was close to 74%.

How actively does Chennai vote? A look at the trends

Geetha Srimathi
CHENNAI

For over two decades, Chennai, the State capital, has trailed the rest of Tamil Nadu in voter turnout. In the 2021 Assembly election, about 61.48% of the city's electorate turned out, while the State average was close to 74%. A similar gap was visible in 2016, when Chennai recorded 61.37%, even as Tamil Nadu crossed 74%. In 2011, a year of higher participation across the State, the city recorded 67.47%, still some distance from the State average. However, that momentum did not carry forward. In the elections that followed, the turnout dropped, and has since remained largely unchanged, staying in the range of 61%-62%. Even as more people are added to the rolls, roughly the same number of voters turns up to vote.

Dip in the voter base

In 2001, Chennai's Assembly constituencies recorded a low turnout of 44.88%, with 14.19 lakh voters out of an electorate of 31.62 lakh casting their votes. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) carried out between the 2001 and 2006 elections led to a dip in Chennai's voter base. Across 14 central constituencies, the electorate fell from 31.6 lakh to 27.71 lakh, a decline of about 12.37%. The verification exercise sought to remove duplicate entries, the names of the deceased, and voters who had moved away.

In 2006, the number of voters rose to 17.91 lakh, pushing the turnout to 64.66%, a jump of nearly 20 percentage points.

Professor Ramu Manivannan, sociopolitical analyst and former Head of the Department of Politics and Public Administration at the University of Madras, attributed the low turnout to what he described as a "metropolitan culture", in which voting is not always seen as imperative. "Urban areas are dominated by middle- and upper-middle-class families whose general attitude is not to turn out, because they feel relatively secure. The same happens in cities like Bengaluru and Mumbai," he said.

North Chennai votes more

Within the city, however, this average hides differences. In 2021, constituencies in North Chennai, such as Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar, Perambur, Royapuram, and Thiru Vi Ka Nagar generally recorded a higher turnout, ranging from about 60% to just over 70%.

In contrast, much of Central and South Chennai – Thousand Lights, T. Nagar, Mylapore, Velachery, Anna Nagar, Virugambakkam, and Saidapet – remained in a tighter and lower band, mostly between 55% and 58%. This pattern is visible in the earlier elections too. In 2011, northern constituencies such as Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar, Royapuram, Perambur, and Kolathur were largely in the high-60% to low-70% range. Central and southern constituencies – including Thousand Lights, T. Nagar, Mylapore, Anna Nagar, and Velachery – were slightly lower, mostly clustered between 65% and 69%.

Home to the working class

Professor Manivannan said the densely populated northern neighbourhoods, home to a larger working-class population, tend to see more consistent voter mobilisation. "When announcements are made on cash transfers or cash coupons for women, they do turn out to vote. After the election, they also come back and ask whether these schemes have been implemented," he said.

The low voter turnout in urban segments is not limited to Chennai. Across cities such as Coimbatore, Madurai, and Tiruchi, core urban seats consistently underperform their districts. In 2021, Coimbatore's urban constituencies hovered in the low-to-mid 60s against a district average of over 72%, while Madurai's central segments slipped back to the low 60s after peaking in 2011, well below the district's 73% range.

VCK returns to its southern origins by contesting from Periyakulam

The VCK started its journey when Thol. Thirumavalavan took over the mantle of the DPI after the death of its leader, A. Malaichamy, in 1989. But it has largely avoided the southern districts. This time, it is seeking to bolster its presence in the southern region by fielding Sakthivel alias Attral Arasu

C. Palanivel Rajan
MADURAI

The Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) traces its roots to the Dalit Panthers Iyakkam (DPI) in Madurai. And it has returned to its southern origins in this Assembly election by contesting from Periyakulam (SC).

The VCK started its journey when Thol. Thirumavalavan took over the mantle of the DPI after the death of its leader, A. Malaichamy, in 1989. Under Mr. Thirumavalavan, it was renamed Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi and continued to operate out of its stronghold in Madurai. But the VCK has largely avoided the southern districts, with a few notable exceptions. In 2001, S.T. Kasthuri Sivasamy contested from Samayanallur (SC) (now Sholavandan) as part of the DMK-led alliance. In 2016, when 25 seats were allocated to it under the Makkal Nala Kootani, the VCK contested from Manamadurai (Sivaganga) and Sholavandan (Madurai). It suffered defeats in these elections.

The nomination of VCK deputy general secretary

Sakthivel, alias Attral Arasu, in Periyakulam this time, as part of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance, is seen as a calculated decision. By entering the race, the VCK seeks to bolster its presence in the southern region, where it is yet to secure a significant victory.

Demographic mix

According to R. Tamilvanan, VCK regional secretary for Theni-Dindigul, Periyakulam, which was part of Madurai district until 1997, has historically served as a stronghold for the party's organisational growth. He said the constituency had a diverse demographic mix of the Scheduled Castes (SCs), caste Hindus, Muslims, and Christians. Periyakulam was unique because of the significant presence of the SCs, especially the Paraiyars, within the town limits. He contrasted this with the neighbouring Madurai, where the SCs were often restricted to rural and semi-urban areas. "This distinct population pattern," he said, "has allowed the party to effectively mobilise voters for



Judicious choice: The candidacy of Sakthivel, a well-known figure among the cadre in Periyakulam, will help to avoid internal frictions seen in other constituencies, where local workers are dissatisfied with the choice of candidates. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

agitations aimed at improving the lot of the community."

'A priority for the party'

According to him, "The history of struggles to uphold the rights of the SCs in this region has long placed this constituency on our priority list."

Writer and researcher Stalin Rajangam said the decision would help to re-root the party in the southern regions. He said the VCK had already demonstrated its significant influence in the area through a series of protests organised for installing a statue of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar in

'If Centre stops assistance or grants, we will not accept it'

It's true we backed the farm laws that had benefits for farmers, but it was Edappadi K. Palaniswami who stalled the project for the extraction of mineral resources in the delta, says AIADMK veteran

INTERVIEW

K.P. Mumusamy

T. Ramakrishnan
SALEM

Taking time off his campaign on Sunday morning in the picturesque village of Ganapuram, about 12 km from Hosur in Krishnagiri district and 135 km from Salem, AIADMK deputy general secretary and former Minister K.P. Munusamy, 73, who is seeking re-election from Veppanahalli, reflected on political challenges to his party in the election, the relevance of freebies, and the impact of the entry of TVK president C. Joseph Vijay into the electoral fray. Edited excerpts:

While the DMK has been heading a strong front for nearly 10 years, the AIADMK has not been able to do so. What is the reason?

More than calling the National Democratic Alliance [headed by the AIADMK in the State] a "strong front", I would say this alliance is marked by one leader's understanding of another leader. It is based on mutual understanding among parties. Unlike our rival coalition, our front has been formed with the visionary thinking of ousting the anti-people government from power.

You are a die-hard supporter of the Dravidian ideology. But



On a strong wicket: K.P. Munusamy, the AIADMK candidate for Veppanahalli, campaigns at Shoolagiri in Krishnagiri. N. BASHKARAN

your adversaries have been claiming that as happened in other States, the BJP will swallow the AIADMK in due course of time. What is your take?

In the 1998 Lok Sabha election, it was Puratchi Thalavi [former Chief Minister Jayalalithaa] who made [Atal Bihari Vajpayee] the Prime Minister. She withdrew her support [to the NDA government] as many of her demands in the interest of Tamil Nadu were not implemented. Who latched on [to the BJP] immediately thereafter? It was the then president of the DMK [M. Karunanidhi]. In the subsequent Lok Sabha poll, they [the DMK] established an alliance [with the BJP] and won. They formed a coalition government [at the Centre] wherein they [the DMK] enjoyed power for five years. In the meantime, they were together during the 2001 Assembly election but did not win. If you go by their argument, the BJP should have swallowed the DMK even in 2001. But it did not. When a party,

which operates for the selfish reasons of a family, can come out [of the alliance with the BJP], how can the AIADMK that works as a people's movement be swallowed?

Are freebies required in a State like T.N.? Why is your party engaged in a contest with the DMK?

A good question! Though the needs of the people have been met to a certain extent, there are still [appliances] that the people do not use or do not get an opportunity to use. Our schemes are meant for enabling them to use them.

DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin has been asking whether the AIADMK is genuinely interested in the welfare of farmers. He says your party had supported three farm laws. Now, it has not opposed the Centre's directive on the withdrawal of incentive for paddy procurement. What is your answer?

Mr. Stalin should not talk

Whistles fly off the shelf this election season

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



Think of whistle and you would perhaps associate it with the humble khakhi-clad bus conductor or your school's PT teacher blowing it to get your attention. Then, Chennai Super Kings got the cricket fans to 'whistle-podu'. Now, whistle is the hot seller among election paraphernalia.

Manufacturers and retailers are reporting a sharp increase in the sale of whistle, the symbol allotted by the Election Commission of India to actor C. Joseph Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in the 2026 election.

Mahindra Singh, one of the manufacturers of toys and whistles, was surprised to notice a significant increase in the demand and sale of whistles in recent times. "We always manufacture close to 30,000 whistles a day and sell them to retailers throughout the year across the country. Usually, there would be a sale of nearly 6,000 whistles a day. This will increase by 20%-25% during the IPL season. But, in the past few weeks, there has been a 60% increase in the sale of whistles in Tamil Nadu," he says.

Demand for TVK colour

While whistles of all colours are sold, there is a specific demand for those in red and yellow. One of the shopkeepers in Chennai selling election paraphernalia says that while every item – mufflers, fans, badge flags of all major parties – are selling well, the demand for whistles is especially high. "We

In high demand: A trader selling whistle, the TVK symbol, at George Town in Chennai. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM



In the past few weeks, there has been a 60% increase in the sale of whistles in Tamil Nadu.

MAHINDRA SINGH, toy and whistle manufacturer

sell 100 pieces for ₹600. The price is high because the demand is steep and also because of an increase in plastic prices owing to the war in West Asia," he said.

Running out of stocks

Esha Shah, who runs a gift store on Narayana Mudali Street in Chennai, said she was surprised by a sudden surge in the sale of whistles. "We didn't quite understand initially. We ran out of stock in no time. Only then did it dawn on us that the party fans and vendors selling on streets and beaches are thronging to buy this device," she added.

As soon as the symbol was allotted to the TVK, Shakeela Devi, a trader in Tiruchi, bought whistles in bulk. "One of the fans who regularly buys them makes a 'whistle' garland," she said.

Pink trumpet trees give the city an unusual pastel spring moment

Tabebuia trees have captivated the residents of neighbourhoods such as Adyar, Greenways Road, Burkit Road, and Anna Nagar; however, environmentalists warn that if they are planted in large numbers, native trees will struggle to thrive

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

When you think about Chennai in April, you wouldn't typically recollect the city in pastels because it is mostly the stark golden yellow of the copper pods that dominate the city.

When the younger crowd saunters past and suddenly spots the pink trumpet tree in bloom, they post on social media with captions that Chennai has turned “pookie” - an affectionate slang term used by Gen Z.

A 25-year-old Nekhaa Narayanan spotted the blossoms along Purasawalkam, New Avadi Road, and Thousand lights in the past week, and said it put a smile on her face.

“I did pause the first time I saw it in Chennai. Since I am back from the United Kingdom, it feels nostalgic looking at the pink blooms. But the way I react is not the same way my parents reacted since they say it has been here for a long time,” says Ms. Narayanan.

“Somehow, it never struck me before the social media hype. Nevertheless, I appreciate these almost overlooked things as I come across them,” she adds.

Pink trumpet tree (*Tabebuia rosea*), copper pod or



Rare sight: While copper pods typically dominate the city's landscape, this year, the pink blooms have caught the eyes of many. R. RAGU

yellow flame tree (*Peltophorum pterocarpum*), flame of the forest (*Butea monosperma*), Indian laburnum or golden shower tree (*Cassia fistula*), bougainvillea (*Bougainvillea spp.*), and jacaranda (*Jacaranda mimosifolia*) are among the trees that bloom across the city.

“Most of the avenue trees are introduced; they are not native. In fact, *Tabebuia rosea* is not suited to a coastal city as it can easily fall during cyclones. It is

a rainforest tree and it was introduced to the city long ago,” says D. Narasimhan, former professor, Department of Botany, University of Madras.

Copper pods

While copper pods typically dominate the city's landscape – and continue to do so – this year, the pink blooms have caught many eyes. “Maybe some of these trees were planted a few years ago and are only now flowering,” he sug-

gests. G.V. Aruna says she saw a cluster of around a dozen trees in bloom along the service road off the Maduravoyal Bypass draw a small crowd for a photoshoot on Sunday. “They were beautiful to look at. If I had the time, I would have liked to take pictures too,” she says.

Tabebuia trees have captivated Chennaites across neighbourhoods such as Adyar, Greenways Road, Burkit Road, Binny Road, and Anna Nagar. Ef-

forts to plant native trees such as pungam, poovarasu, odhiyam, vengai, kadukkai, and thandrikai have been under way for years.

“It's not that trees like *Tabebuia* are not beautiful, they are. But people tend to get carried away by beauty alone. When they are introduced and planted in large numbers, it becomes a problem, because our native trees then struggle to thrive,” says Shoba of Nizhal.

Post a temporary spike, Metro Rail's ridership plummets again

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With the restoration of suburban services, Chennai Metro Rail's spike in ridership has seen a decline in recent times.

On February 20, Southern Railway decreased the suburban train services on the Beach-Tambaram-Chengalpattu section, which resulted in a surge in Chennai Metro Rail's ridership.

But since Southern Railway has restored the services and full-day operations, the Chennai Metro Rail has been witnessing a gradual dip in the ridership.

The term-break or study holidays for college and

school students have also contributed to the reduction in ridership.

Dip in last two weeks

From October 2025 to January 2026, the daily average ridership was around three lakh. While in February, it increased sharply to 3.43 lakh, in March, it dipped to 3.28 lakh. Data shows a ridership dip of 15,000 to 20,000 passengers over the last two weeks.

According to officials of the Chennai Metro Rail Limited (CMRL), it is during the weekdays that they receive maximum ridership, including office-goers, college and school students.

“Many of the suburban travellers have returned to

commuting by that [suburban] network. Also, college and school students either have exam holidays or their term-break. This is another major cause for the drop in the ridership. But we have to remember that there is always some reduction in the ridership between March and May almost every year,” an official said.

In June, when the regular travellers, including the students, return to their routine, it will be clear how the graph of the ridership stands.

The CMRL could increase its patronage only when initiatives like last-mile connectivity services are provided in all the 41 stations of the network.

Jewellery shop employee held for stealing gold coins

CHENNAI: The police arrested Shivadev, 32, for stealing gold coins from a jewellery shop in T. Nagar on Sunday. The police said Shivadev works at the jewellery shop and stole 170 grams of gold coins. He confessed to the crime after an internal inquiry and returned 40 grams of the coins a few days back. Since, he did not return the rest, the shop's manager filed a complaint with the Teynampet police, who arrested Shivadev.

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RISE 04:05 SET 16:25

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Chennai City	34	28

Chennai Airport Today

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Chennai Airport Tomorrow

37°C The weather will be dry. Day will be very warm. Night will be comfortable.

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THE HINDU

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According to the Retention Policy and Protocol for Medical Records Management, the medical records identified as inactive for the year 2020, specifically from January 1, 2020

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People across Tamil Nadu want a change; there is anti-incumbency: AIADMK leader

Former Minister D. Jayakumar says every party in the alliance has its own ideology, but the AIADMK will not be influenced by them. Confident of a win because of the party's strong voter base and coalition votes, the Royapuram candidate promises to develop infrastructure and fulfil the people's needs

INTERVIEW

D. Jayakumar

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

The people across the State want a change. There is anti-incumbency. The government is anti-people. Law and order is an issue, says former Minister and AIADMK leader D. Jayakumar.

The AIADMK's strongman in Chennai shares his views on his own electoral battle, the impact of parties such as the TVK and the NTK, and on the AIADMK's allies this election. Edited excerpts:

What is your assessment of the Royapuram Assembly Constituency?

In my constituency, the voters have complained about the increase in property tax and electricity charges. The people have understood that the anti-incumbency vote against the DMK should not be wasted by not voting for the AIADMK. We will win because we have a strong voter base and we have our coalition votes. People have realised that I have been with them during their struggle; that I created housing infrastructure for original inhabitants, and developed bridges and



Promising development: D. Jayakumar during a poll campaign in Royapuram. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

civic infrastructure. The DMK MLA was not accessible during the last five years.

What impact do you think parties like the TVK and the NTK have in the course of the election campaign?

NTK had secured 8% of votes in the previous election. The TVK has not proved its vote share in any election. We are not sure if the vote share of the NTK will be the same this election. Some NTK and VCK votes may go to the TVK. In Royapuram, these parties have no significant impact.

In some parts of the State, the TVK is likely to draw votes of the DMK alliance. [However] It is not likely to have an impact on the AIADMK votes in my

Assembly constituency.

What are the expectations of the voters in your constituency?

The voters need infrastructure development, better roads, street lights, and uninterrupted power supply and water supply. As part of the smart city project, they [the DMK government] damaged M.C. Road in Royapuram, which provides a source of livelihood for over 10,000 people. They did not hold a public consultation before implementing the project. People want the project to be dropped. Once we return to power, we will drop it.

M.C. Road is an iconic location in North Chennai. The traders need a wide carriageway. More than

one lakh people visit the neighbourhood during festival seasons. We will provide better infrastructure, including toilets, seating, and water supply in the commercial area, and listen to the people.

What is the likely impact of the delimitation of areas such as Kasimedu, which used to be an AIADMK stronghold, on the electoral outcome?

Ward 43, formerly ward 14, is my place of birth. That ward – covering Kasimedu Harbour and Tondiarpet – used to give me additional votes. In a bid to defeat me, the delimitation exercise was used to merge the ward with Dr. Radhakrishnan Nagar Assembly Constituency. But after the de-

limitation, the people of ward 48 and ward 53 also supported me and I won from the constituency in 2011. This election, I will get more votes in such areas.

AIADMK's alliance with parties that are against secular values have come under attack. What is your reaction?

The AIADMK is a party that transcends caste, religion, race, and linguistic groups. For us, all are equal before the law. We will not refrain from speaking up against those who deny the rights of the minorities. The coalition is only an arrangement to contest from various constituencies ahead of elections, but our ideologies are different. The ideology of the BJP is different from that of the AIADMK. But the DMK is our common enemy, and we must defeat it.

How difficult has it been competing in this election, particularly in trying to convince a section of the electors who do not trust parties in your alliance?

We have assured people that we will not support any policy decisions that will affect them. We want peace and harmony, and the rights of minorities must be protected. Voters will make a decision.

Do you really think that

all your alliance partners are in pursuit of social justice?

Every party in the alliance has its own ideology. We will not be influenced by the ideology of other parties in the alliance. But the AIADMK is determined to protect social justice, because our leaders have already proved that we are capable of protecting the interests of the weaker sections through our struggle for social justice.

During the tenure of the AIADMK in 1991-1996, *Amma* [Chief Minister Jayalithaa] was given the title "Samooga Neethi Kaatha Veeranganai" by Dravidar Kazhagam president K. Veeramani when I was the Minister for Backward Classes.

When the court ordered the State government to reduce the quantum of reservation from 69% to 50%, we convened an all-party meeting and went to New Delhi seeking Constitutional protection for 69% reservation.

Amma was successful in bringing about an amendment to the Constitution to include the Act in the Ninth Schedule. Had it been the DMK government, Mr. Karunanidhi (former Chief Minister and DMK president) would have shrugged his shoulders and moved on, making no such efforts to protect social justice against the orders of the Supreme Court and High Court.

INBRIEF



Governor condoles death of playback singer Asha Bhosle

Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar on Sunday condoled the death of playback singer Asha Bhosle. A social media post of the Lok Bhavan quoted the Governor as saying: "Deeply saddened by the demise of legendary playback singer Tmt.Asha Bhosle, whose timeless voice enriched Indian music and touched millions of hearts across generations. Her unparalleled contribution to the world of music will forever remain an inspiration. My heartfelt condolences to her family, friends, and admirers. May her soul rest in peace."

Six persons arrested for leaking *Jana Nayagan*

The police on Sunday arrested six persons involved in leaking Vijay's film *Jana Nayagan* on multiple digital platforms. According to a press release, a case was registered based on a complaint filed by KVN Productions on Saturday. Based on the investigation by a special team, six persons were arrested for uploading and disseminating pirated copies through cloud storage platforms, and sharing drive links. The digital evidence was seized from them.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper. thehindu.com) carries explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (April 13, Monday), the following articles are available:

■ Between 14 years and the gallows: the Sriharan vacuum newsth.live/capitalpunishment

■ Study unravels why men experience more skin infections than women newsth.live/skininfection

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

From balloons to flash mobs, city amps up voter awareness

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

From giant balloons at key junctions to flash mobs in malls, election awareness activities are being held across the Chennai district ahead of the Assembly election to promote 100% voter turnout.

Giant balloons displaying messages on voting were installed at prominent locations, including Ripon Buildings, Ezhilagam, Anna Salai, and near the Koyambedu flyover, urging voters to participate in the 'Election festival - the grand festival of Tamil Nadu'.

A voter awareness marathon was organised near the Peravallur police station in Kolathur constituency. A selfie point was set up at the venue, where participants took photographs promoting 100% turnout, and certificates were distributed.

Focus on PwDs

In Chepauk-Thiruvallikeni constituency, more than 100 persons with disabilities (PwDs) took part in an awareness rally on Kamarajar Salai near the Marina on Saturday.

Other awareness programmes included demonstrations on voting using Braille for visually impaired persons at the Tamil Nadu Association of the

Blind in Tondiarpet and sign language-based outreach for hearing and speech impaired voters at a centre in Santhome.

A flash mob to raise awareness of voting rights was organised at Express Avenue Mall in Thousand Lights constituency on March 28.

Folk performances, including karagattam, gaana songs and kummi, were held in Perambur and R.K. Nagar constituencies.

Video clips and messages issued by the Election Commission were screened on 100 electronic display boards and at 1,000 bus shelters across the city, alongside campaign material centred on the mascot "Namma Thanga".

Mobile units used to raise awareness included vehicles with LED screens, battery-operated vehicles used for door-to-door collection of solid waste, refuse compactors, and government buses.

In Virugambakkam constituency, pamphlets urging people to vote on polling day were distributed to traders and members of the public in the Koyambedu market area on March 31. Stickers were affixed to shops.

In Perambur constituency, awareness programmes were conducted at an old-age home in Vyasarpad.

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E-TENDER NOTICE**
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Dy. Chief Engineer (Construction)-I, North-Western Railway, Jodhpur through for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders (Open Tender - Two packet system) for the following work :- 1. Tender No. T.No. JU/Const./T-04-R-2025-26-BGKT-PH-II 2. Name of the work with its location : Development of Maintenance infrastructure (Civil Mechanical) involving construction of PEB structures for Workshops, Training school and other ancillary works in connection with maintenance cum workshop depot for Vande Bharat Sleeper trains at Bhagat Ki Kothi, Jodhpur as per conditions under WTA-527 (Phase-II), 3. Approx. cost of work : Rs. 93,14,60,755.35 4. Earnest Money to be deposited : Rs. 1,86,29,200.00 5. Tender Closing date & time : 07.05.2026 upto 15.00 hrs. 6. Detail of particular where e-tender can be seen & filled up : www.ireps.gov.in 7. Official email address : dyceju1@gmail.com 527-CR/26
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**NORTH WESTERN RAILWAY
E-TENDER NOTICE**
No. 03 to 06-26-27
No. 333-WNW Running Room/BNN/2025 Dated : 10.04.2026
Divl. Rly. Manager, N.W.Rly. Bikaner for and on behalf of President of India invites open E-Tender for the following works up to 15.00 hours on 30.04.2026 as below:-
Tender No. : 03 Name of Work with its Location : Extension of RUB of size 2 x 4.5m x 5.10 m at Km 43.445 on Hanumangarh - Sadulpur section. Provision of Pathway, Water Connection, Approach Road & Boundary wall etc. and track works at Ellenabad in c/w provision of extension of existing TMC siding along with facilities in connection with RGM-24 under ADEN/Hanumangarh II. **Approx. Cost of Work :** Rs. 30257353.10 **Earnest Money :** Rs. 605200.00 **Tender No. : 04 Name of Work with its Location :** Construction of new running room in lieu of old running room at Bhiwani under ADEN/Bhiwani. **Approx. Cost of Work :** Rs. 93836792.31 **Earnest Money :** Rs. 1876700.00 **Tender No. : 05 Name of Work with its Location :** Extension of existing TMC shed in connection with Infrastructure enhancement of Satellite Track Machine Depot, Lalgarh/Bikaner with the provision of staff facilities under ADEN/HQ/Bikaner. **Approx. Cost of Work :** Rs. 14349340.01 **Earnest Money :** Rs. 287000.00 **Tender No. : 06 Name of Work with its Location :** Shifting of cross over P-101/103 and provision of dead end at Pilibanga for safe movement of trains under ADEN/Hanumangarh-I. **Approx. Cost of Work :** Rs. 1817634.94 **Earnest Money :** Rs. 36400.00 **Note:-** Other terms & conditions will be shown on the website www.ireps.gov.in 531-CR/26
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OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

A.H.V. PRAVEEN passed away on 12/04/2026 at his residence in Mahalingapuram. Funeral from 3:00 pm, 13/04/2026. Mobile : 9884429139



Sri. K. N. VARADARAJAN
(Former Executive Director Devi Theatre Chennai)
DOB: (12-07-1941) - DOD: (07-04-2026)

We deeply mourn the untimely demise of our beloved uncle
Sri. K. N. Varadarajan
on 7th April 2026 at 10:20 pm at his residence.
He was a respected elder and a guiding force to many, leaving behind a legacy that will be cherished forever. His Swamy Kariyam will be performed around 12 noon at his residence on Monday 13 April 2026.
Address: The Heritage Apartment, 9th Floor G&H, No 2, Fourth Cross Street, Omnes Road, Kippak, Chennai - 600010
—Fondly remembered by—
K.N.K. Venkateswaran
K.N.K. Suresh
K. Ravindran & Family Members
Contact: 9 4 4 2 8 2 8 4 4



With profound grief we announce the demise of



Dhanalakshmi Govindan
Age 89 years
wife of (late) Dr. R. Govindan (Neurosurgeon)
expired on 12th April 2026

Mourning By
Rajeshwari Sekar
Dr. N. Sekar
Jayshree Sridhar
Dr. K. Sridhar
Grand Children
Great Grand Children
Shri Govindan Mahal
Kumbalkonam

REMEMBRANCE



DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



A. RAGHAVAN
We miss you
Dear Ones

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

8th ANNIVERSARY on 13-04-2026
ஒருக்கம், புகழ் இயக்கங்கள் என்று 82 ஆண்டுகள் புகழ் பெற்றவர் அந்தரங்கம். இப்பத்திர ஆண்டுக்கு என் வாழ்க்கைத் துணை நலமாக இருந்து என் உயிர்வு கவந்தாய், என்னை இயக்குவாய்.

Mrs. O.R. NIRMALA, B.A.,
(Retd.) Controller, Office of the J.C.C. of Imports & Exports, Chennai
10.04.1936 13.04.2018
FRIDAY FRIDAY
—Fondly Remembered by—
Husband: V.RAJAMANGHARAN, M.A. (Retd.) Deputy Director (I & PR), Chennai-9)
Son: V.R. Murugavel, B.E.
Daughter: S.Thanish Selvi, B.Sc.
Daughter-in-law: Sharmila M.R.S.C.
Son-in-law: M.Sundar Rajan, M.Tech
Grand Children: Selvi.M, Prarthana, M.Vijaya Prathan, S.sai Krishna
Mobile: 94449 51564

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



3rd ANNIVERSARY
K. JAGANNATHAN
S/o P. KUMARAGURUBARAN

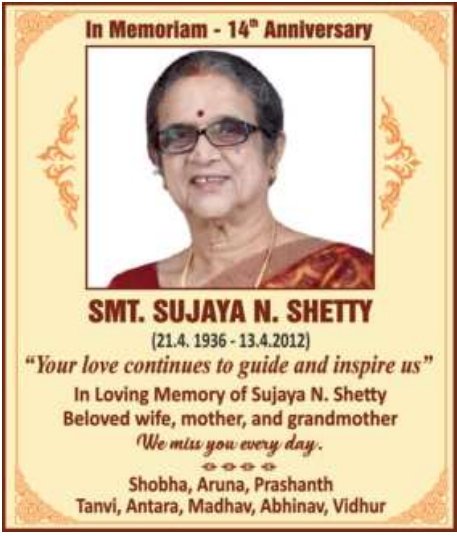


REMEMBRANCE
Thiru.N.T.S.SOUNDAPPA CHETTIAR
24.8.1917 - 13.4.2003
F/O DR.S.VARADARAJAN
ESSVEE HOSPITAL
"YOU ARE ALWAYS LIVING WITH US AND BLESSING US"
By Family Members

First Birthday in Heaven

Kalaipuli G Sekaran
06.06.1952 - 13.04.2025
Fondly remembered by your family

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES



DEATH ANNIVERSARIES
"You will be a crown of splendor in the Lord's hand, a royal diadem in the hand of your God." - Isaiah 62:3
4th Year Remembrance of a Kind & Adorable Soul



Mrs. Shantha Rajiah B.A., B.T.,
1st March 1947 - 13th April 2022
Your life was a quiet blessing, your presence a sacred gift. Your memory glows as a gentle, guiding light. Loved beyond words, missed beyond measure, you remain with us - in every silence, always.
We Miss You Guardian Angel !
Rajiah, Prabhakar, Nimmy, Suthakar Priya, Sudershan, William, Adrian, Amelia

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

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Student’s death raises concern over ‘caste bias’ in Kerala colleges

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The suspected campus suicide of R.L. Nithin Raj, a first-year student at the An-jarakandy Dental College in Kannur district of Kerala, on Friday, has caused a public outcry and raised questions about casteism on higher education campuses, despite constitutional safeguards against social discrimination.

Nithin Raj’s body was brought to his rented house at Uzhamalackal in Thiruvananthapuram early on Sunday.

An audio clip suspected to be of the student narrating the humiliation he allegedly faced from some faculty members and classmates surfaced on media. The State Police are examining the veracity of the voice message. According to the police, Nithin Raj had died after a fall from the college’s third floor.

Meanwhile, the dental college authorities have suspended two faculty members, M.K. Ram and K.T. Sangeetha Nambiar, pending inquiry in connection with Nithin Raj’s death.

A large crowd had gathered to say farewell to Nithin Raj, whose father works as a handyman and part-time painter. Communist Party of India (Marxist) district secretary for Thiruvananthapuram, A.A. Rahim, MP, who called on the bereaved family, told presspersons that Nithin Raj had faced discrimination in the college because he was from a Dalit family. “The

The dental college has suspended two faculty members in connection with Nithin Raj’s death

CPI(M) demands a comprehensive inquiry,” he said.

All India Congress Committee (AICC) general secretary K.C. Venugopal said Nithin Raj’s parents have testified to the ordeal their ward endured at the college. “The Congress demands a foolproof inquiry,” he said.

Nithin Raj’s teachers and classmates remembered him as a brilliant student with excellent hand-writing.

Audio message
In the audio message, the speaker alleges that a teacher insulted him in the staff room, used abusive language, mocked his mother and issued threats. He also recounts repeated humiliation in class, including public ridicule and marking penalties.

The police have already recorded the statements of the victim’s relatives and those who took him to the hospital. A detailed statement from his parents and relatives will be taken later. The police said they would also check the phone recordings to analyse the cause of death. “It [audio clip] has to be verified and the source identified,” a senior investigating police officer told *The Hindu*.

(Those in distress can contact TeleMANAS at 14416 to seek help)

LDF will win over 90 seats, return to power: Govindan

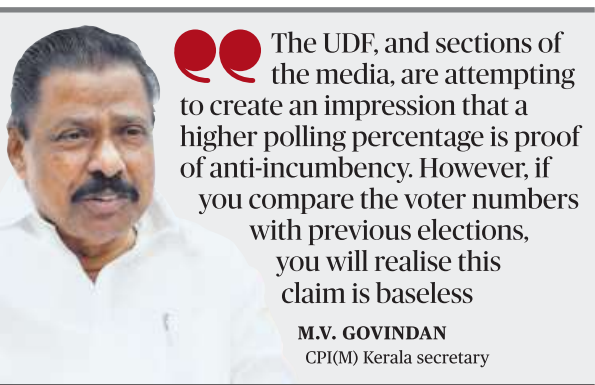
CPI(M) State secretary rejects speculation that a high polling percentage in the Assembly election might be an indicator of anti-incumbency, as SIR has excluded a considerable number of voters

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Expressing confidence that the Left Democratic Front (LDF) would come back to power for an unprecedented third term by winning over 90 seats, Communist Party of India (Marxist) State secretary M.V. Govindan said on Sunday that speculation around high polling percentages in the Assembly election was baseless.

Addressing a press conference at the AKG Centre here, he said that the incumbent MLAs of the LDF would emerge victorious as the voters had shown an intense wish for continuity.

Mr. Govindan rejected speculation that a high



polling percentage in the election might be an indicator of a change in government.

SIR impact
“The United Democratic Front (UDF) as well as sections of the media have been attempting to create an impression that a higher

polling percentage is proof of anti-incumbency. However, if you compare the voter numbers with previous elections, you will realise that this claim is baseless. Compared with the 2021 Assembly election, the number of voters has reduced considerably after the special intensive

Siddaramaiah’s political secretary ‘asked’ to go

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU / SHIVAMOGGA

The fallout of the alleged anti-party activities by some Muslim leaders of the Congress in the Davangere South Assembly constituency where bypolls were held on April 9, is beginning to surface.

A day after Karnataka Pradesh Congress Committee Minority Cell chairman Abdul Jabbar tendered his resignation, Chief Minister

Siddaramaiah’s political secretary Naseer Ahmed is learnt to have been asked to step down.

The two Muslim leaders, along with Housing Minister B.Z. Zameer Ahmed Khan – who had lobbied strongly for a Muslim candidate in Davangere South – are being accused of not taking part in the election campaign, threatening the election outcome for Congress’s official nominee, Samarth Mallikarjun.

Three boys drown while swimming in A.P.

The Hindu Bureau
PADERU

Three boys drowned while swimming in the Matsyagedda river in Alluri Sitharama Raju (ASR) district of Andhra Pradesh on Sunday, police said.

The deceased were identified as Arshit, 11, and Koda Praveen, 10, from G.K. Veedhi, and Pangi Bablu, 10, from Panneda in Pedabayalu mandal. All three were studying at the

upper primary level in the Government Tribal Welfare Boys Residential School at Panneda.

Pedabayalu Sub-Inspector T. Venkatesh said a group of five boys had gone to Matsyagedda for swimming. The local people rescued two boys, while Arshit, Bablu and Praveen went missing. Their bodies were later retrieved.

Pedabayalu police has registered a case and an investigation is on.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday

TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Thunderstorm accompanied with lightning & gusty winds very likely at isolated places over Assam, Meghalaya, Nagaland, Manipur, Mizoram and Tripura. Thunderstorm accompanied with Lightning very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Coastal Karnataka, Kerala and South Interior Karnataka

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN		
Agartala		34.7		25.2	Kozhikode		36.8		28.4
Ahmedabad		40.7		25.7	Kurnool		42.1		30.0
Aizawl		32.4		18.4	Lucknow		36.6		20.0
Allahabad		39.8		20.6	Madurai		38.4		26.2
Bengaluru		34.4		24.0	Mangaluru		33.2		26.0
Bhopal		38.6		20.4	Mumbai		34.2		27.4
Bhubaneswar		37.7		26.0	Mysuru		36.0		20.4
Chandigarh		31.9		14.8	New Delhi		34.3		18.7
Chennai		36.5		27.3	Patna		37.2		23.6
Coimbatore		37.2		25.6	Port Blair		32.6		25.8
Dehradun		29.7		12.8	Puducherry		32.7		25.1
Gangtok		11.4		10.6	Pune		39.8		20.3
Goa		33.6		25.2	Raipur		41.0		23.1
Guwahati		30.6		20.1	Ranchi		34.8		18.0
Hubballi		00.0		00.0	Shillong		00.0		00.0
Hyderabad		39.4		27.0	Shimla		20.5		9.0
Imphal		28.6		15.9	Srinagar		20.8		5.5
Jaipur		34.7		24.6	Thiruvananthapuram		35.2		24.7
Kochi		32.6		28.0	Tiruchi		37.9		26.6
Kohima		17.7		11.4	Vijayawada		00.0		00.0
Kolkata		35.2		26.2	Visakhapatnam		34.1		28.0

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad		73	62		184		255
Bengaluru		40		38		86	136
Chennai		20		11		117	231
Delhi		33		27	37		117
Hyderabad		15		13	35		58
Kolkata		80		88	35		100
Lucknow		12		10	43		165
Mumbai		10		50	42		117
Pune			35	47		83	117
Visakhapatnam		40		47	20		55

Air Quality Code: Poor Moderate Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease.

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Of war and peace

Why we need to go beyond the history of war and conflict in our educational institutions

Mini Krishnan

Winning is so deeply embedded in our psyche that history is generally considered a chronicle of power; a list of who crushed whom and descriptions of rivalries amongst the strong.

Focus on conflict

The destruction of Troy in 1193 BCE, Alexander’s defeat of Raja Purushothaman in 326 BCE, the Norman conquest of England in 1066, the fall of Constantinople in 1453, and the First Battle of Panipat in 1556. The siege of ... the war of ... the sacking of ... After all the fiery wars came the Cold War.

The history of war and conflict is a focus on the political trends and divisive forces of the world and has traditionally been a part of the political agenda of education. “Students

need to know the history of their nation,” is the foundation of this study programme. They do, they do. But is that all?

For a long time, it was uppermost in peoples’ minds because hand-to-hand skirmishes and field battles between countries and adjacent regions were continuous, with the lives of whole populations under threat all the time.

Today, proxy wars are fought and, for reasons of national face-keeping or hand-washing, we continue to live with huge and unjust invasions of fellow humans that are far away enough to not disturb our day-to-day lives.

Poor second

My concern is: why does the intellectual history of mankind come a poor second to the history of bloody struggles between countries and civilisations? The calendar of man’s artistic and technological as-

cent should be given more importance than it is. Given the academic atmosphere of classrooms, it could surely be both interesting and relevant.

Look at just one example in the history of ideas: When Islam and Christianity were locked in a fight to the death for the control of the Holy land, a community of European monks and scholars were in peaceful contact with their more advanced colleagues: scholars who were producing works of science and technology through translations into and out of Arabic in the great knowledge centres and libraries of Baghdad. There are many such instances.

Can we not also bring the untold his-and-her stories of the “daily”ness of the human experience into classrooms? What were peoples’ lives like away from the sites of war? For instance, given the recent spread of interest in global

cuisine, the history of food and habitats would be fascinating. Surely a good way to expand geography classes? Climate, vegetation, food habits, and food history.

Missing element

The missing element in social awareness of the nature of the human experience in History is a vital image of the day-to-day measures of life. The very language of teaching and the importance teachers give to research and human ingenuity would go a long way in shifting the schoolgoer’s mind away from the nervous excitement that conflict generates.

What history and whose story? Telling students stories other than war stories would be a step towards their holistic development. Children raised with some emphasis on the positive side of human evolution would be less likely to de-

velop prejudices about ‘foreigners’ or hostility towards people of different beliefs and social practices.

No amount of academic achievement can make up for the lack of emotional and life skills. What if one of our students grew up to be a brilliant scientist whose children are terrified of her? Is that the successful human being we want to raise?

The greatest life skill is learning to understand that other people are as important as yourself and developing an empathetic attitude to all life.

Start early

This training can begin at an early age: caring for people around you. It is the lack of this value that leads to all the misunderstandings, fears, and even hatred of anyone who is not like oneself. In fact we have been watching with agony and alarm at what is happening in West Asia where one group of people think nothing of taking away the rights and lives of another.

Without value education, without peace education, our institutions are perfect training grounds for war because they place such a premium on success for the self and the self alone.

At least a part of History in classrooms should be an account of our humanity and our children should receive the universal message from the Mundaka Upanishad: “Like a thousand sparks from a blazing fire are we...” of the same

nature, the same origin. Let’s give the history of peace a place in our institutions.

The writer consults for the Tamil Nadu Textbook and Educational Services Corporation (TNTB & ESC).

Initiative

ideaForge Technology has launched the Who Are the Next Idiots? initiative in collaboration with IIT-Bombay.

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Elusive deal

U.S. and Iran must continue diplomatic efforts to end the war

Twenty-one hours of talks in Islamabad between the U.S. and Iran ended without a breakthrough. That no agreement emerged from the first post-ceasefire meeting is not surprising. Nor does it mean that the process has collapsed. Even before the talks began, it was evident that there were huge gaps between the two sides. The two-week ceasefire announced by U.S. President Donald Trump on April 8, after 39 days of war, looked shaky from day one as Israel stepped up air strikes on Lebanon, killing hundreds. Both Iran, and Pakistan, which mediated the truce, claimed that Lebanon was covered by the ceasefire, while Israel wants to continue the war. There was no mutually agreed framework for the Islamabad talks either. Iran claimed that its 10-point proposal was accepted as the basis for discussion, while the White House said that the ten points that it received were different from those in the proposal that Tehran had released. Despite differences, the meeting between U.S. Vice-President J.D. Vance and the Iranian delegation headed by Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, the first face-to-face senior-level meeting between the two sides since the 1979 revolution, marked significant progress.

According to Mr. Vance and Iranian officials, three issues remain contentious – Iran’s nuclear programme, its control over the Strait of Hormuz, and Israeli strikes on Lebanon. Notably, Iran was willing to make a deal on its nuclear programme, the strait was fully open, and the Lebanon situation had not escalated into a full-scale ground invasion before the U.S. and Israel launched the war on Iran on February 28. U.S.-Israeli bombings have not met their stated objectives. On the contrary, the war has hardened Iran’s position and triggered a whole new crisis over the Strait of Hormuz. Mr. Trump, who unilaterally sabotaged the Obama-era Iran nuclear deal in 2018, should not have started this war. But now that the war has turned out to be a strategic setback for the U.S. and its regional allies, Washington must focus on a negotiated settlement without ultimatums. Iran, for its part, realises that it holds significant leverage, but it should avoid overplaying its hand. Tehran needs credible security guarantees against future aggression and support for reconstruction, while the wanton Israeli killings in Lebanon must end. At the same time, Iran should be open to concessions on the nuclear front and to fully reopening the Strait of Hormuz to global traffic. The Islamabad meeting could be a starting point, if both sides sustain dialogue while holding the ceasefire.

Tourism and trade

Consensus is vital in leveraging the strategic importance of Nicobar

The Union government’s ₹92,000 crore mega-infrastructure project for the holistic development of the Great Nicobar Island (GNI) by building it up as a port and tourism-led economy has gathered speed in the last six months, even as concerns remain about its impact on the Island’s ecology and the rights of local populations, the Nicobarese and the Shompen – two indigenous tribal groups. The Andaman and Nicobar Islands administration has notified a draft master plan for the project. Apart from the International Container Transhipment Port (ICTP), the airport, and power plants, the draft master plan envisions developing the GNI as a “seaside destination in a pristine, unspoilt, protected environment”, outlining plans for business, adventure, biodiversity tourism, family entertainment, amusement parks, etc., along with adequate social infrastructure for healthcare, education, and livelihood. The draft is planned for a projected population of over 3.36 lakh by 2055, by which time the expected tourist inflow will be a million a year. Over 70% of the direct employment the government hopes to create will be in tourism and allied sectors. The current population of the GNI is a little less than 10,000. This transformation of the GNI, aided by the ICTP, is crucial to leverage the “strategic importance” of the Island’s location at the western entrance to the Malacca Strait. The draft plan has said the port will help India achieve its “aims to capture a significant share in global sea trade”.

But while the administration has sought public suggestions and objections for 30 days, it remains unclear till when this window will remain open, given that the draft does not mention when it was notified. This draft plan follows another draft plan to relocate local Nicobarese communities to make way for the project. The two plans seemingly contradict each other with regard to where existing populations may be relocated, which has renewed fears among these groups. These communities have been opposing the project’s clearance since 2022, alleging that their forest rights had not been settled. While the National Green Tribunal has set aside concerns about the project’s impact on the GNI’s biodiversity by citing its “strategic importance”, a challenge to the project’s clearances remains in the Calcutta High Court. Some have also questioned the project’s commercial and naval merits. Considering that the project aims to irreversibly alter the demography, and ecology of the GNI, the most prudent path for the government is to take the time needed to build a more holistic consensus over it.

Delimitation, and not women’s reservation, is the issue

The Prime Minister is making appeals to Opposition parties to support Bills that the government wants to bulldoze in a special session of Parliament when the election campaign in Tamil Nadu and West Bengal will be at its peak. There can be only one reason for the extraordinary hurry, which is to derive political advantage and place the Opposition on the defensive.

The Prime Minister is, as usual, being economical with the truth.

The Parliament passed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 unanimously in September 2023 during a special session. The Adhiniyam introduced Article 334-A in the Constitution which mandated one-third reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabhas, scheduled to come into effect after the completion of the next Census and the Census-based delimitation process. The Opposition had not asked for this condition. In fact, the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, Shri Mallikarjun Kharge, had forcefully demanded that the reservation provision be implemented from the 2024 Lok Sabha elections itself. For reasons best known to itself, the government did not agree.

Now, we are given to understand that Article 334-A will be amended to make women’s reservation applicable from 2029 itself. Why did it take the Prime Minister 30 months to make his U-turn? And why can he not wait a few weeks to convene the special session? Opposition leaders have written to the government not once but thrice requesting that an all-party meeting be convened after the last phase of elections is over in West Bengal on April 29, to discuss what the new proposals of the government are. But that perfectly reasonable request has been turned down. Instead, the Prime Minister has resorted to writing op-eds, making appeals to political parties, and organising *sammelans*. It is an underhand tactic that reflects the Prime Minister’s one-upmanship and his ‘my way or the highway’ approach to decision-making.

Lessons from the past

Contrast this with the manner in which the 73rd



Sonia Gandhi

Chairperson of the Congress Parliamentary Party

Any delimitation involving an increase in the strength of the Lok Sabha must be politically – and not just arithmetically – equitable

and 74th Constitution Amendment Bills were finally passed by Parliament in April 1993 and June 1993, respectively. The Bills took almost five years of discussion and debate, following which reservation for women in elections to panchayats and *nagarpalikas* became law. This was a singular achievement of the late Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi. Today, there are about 15 lakh elected women representatives in rural and urban local bodies, constituting over 40% of the total. The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 stands on the shoulders of this achievement.

The last decadal Census was due in 2021. The Modi government kept postponing it. One consequence of this has been that over 10 crore people have been deprived of their legal entitlements under the National Food Security Act, 2013 that provides the basis for the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana. Census operations have begun only after an inexplicable delay of five years. It is being proudly claimed that it is a digital Census. Senior officials have themselves publicly declared that because of its digital nature, most of the population enumeration numbers will be available in 2027 itself. The government’s excuses for its tearing hurry to call this session and conduct delimitation are evidently hollow.

Almost exactly a year ago, the Prime Minister announced that the 2027 Census would also be a caste census. This was after filing affidavits in the Supreme Court and answering questions in Parliament rejecting the idea of conducting a caste census. This was also after the Prime Minister accused Congress leaders calling for a caste census as suffering from what he called “an urban naxal mindset”. Be that as it may, Census 2027 is supposed to enumerate the population by caste in order to give greater meaning to social justice and empowerment. Bihar and Telangana have carried out comprehensive caste surveys in their respective States, with the whole process not taking more than six months.

It is clear, therefore, that the propaganda that a caste census will delay the publication of the Census 2027 is just not true. In fact, the Prime Minister’s real intention now is to further delay and derail the caste census.

Why India’s established elite is afraid of taking risks

In F. Scott Fitzgerald’s *The Beautiful and Damned*, Anthony Patch possesses everything except the willingness to act. He has education, social connections, and even reasonable intelligence. What destroys him is not external circumstance but internal paralysis. He spends years waiting for his grandfather’s inheritance, and by the time it arrives, he has forgotten how to exercise agency. The money comes, but the man capable of using it meaningfully no longer exists. While this might seem like a distant literary tragedy, versions of it are unfolding across India’s business elite today.

Something unusual has been happening in Indian business over the past few years. Well-managed family businesses with healthy cash flows are being sold not because they face distress or strategic dead ends, but because the next generation prefers liquidity over operational continuity. VIP Industries, a leading player in the Indian branded luggage market, is one example.

What makes this pattern strange is that these exits are happening during a period of unprecedented opportunity. India’s domestic market is expanding, global supply chains are diversifying, and capital is abundant. Yet many second- and third-generation business families seem to be choosing passive investment avenues, such as running family offices, over the businesses their parents built, even though these generations are better educated and more globally networked than their predecessors. Why are they choosing not to build?

Preservation over creation

Peter Turchin’s theory of elite overproduction offers one lens for understanding this. He argues that societies become unstable when they produce more credentialed elite aspirants than the number of elite positions available. The usual result is political instability as the surplus elites challenge the incumbents for power. But India seems to be generating a different outcome. While there is clearly an oversupply of educated, well-connected individuals relative to the number of influential positions, rather than triggering open conflict or displacement, what the country is seeing is a risk retreat among incumbents.

Existing business families are not being forced



Kiran Mahasuar

Assistant Professor in the Strategy Area at S.P. Jain Institute of Management and Research (SPJIMR). Views expressed are personal

The inherited elite, the people who control the most capital and have the most institutional access, are opting out of the riskiest and most transformational kinds of building

out. They are choosing custodianship over creation. Capital gets recycled into assets that preserve wealth, rather than create it, such as real estate portfolios, financial market positions, and established brands. Succession planning becomes about maintaining control, and not about expanding the frontier of what the family enterprise does. The result is stasis rather than revolution. India has surplus elite capacity, but that capacity is not being channelled into high-risk, long-gestation ventures. It is being absorbed into wealth preservation.

The R&D problem

Consider how India’s private sector approaches Research and Development (R&D). As a percentage of revenue, Indian companies spend dramatically less on R&D than their counterparts in China, South Korea, or Taiwan. This is not because Indian firms are less profitable or because the regulatory environment makes R&D impossible. The issue seems to be that R&D represents exactly the kind of risk that second-generation business families find unattractive. It requires patient capital; and results are uncertain. Failures are visible and cannot be easily explained to minority shareholders accustomed to steady dividends. The payoff, if it comes, arrives years later and may benefit successors rather than the decision-maker. By contrast, acquiring an existing brand, expanding into real estate, or optimising an inherited manufacturing process offers more legible returns with less reputational exposure. The anomaly becomes clearer when you compare today’s business elite with first-generation entrepreneurs. When Dhirubhai Ambani built the Patalganga refinery, he was betting everything on an outcome that was far from certain. The investment could not be quickly reversed, and failure would have been total and public. But that irreversibility was precisely what made the bet transformational. India’s pivot to a market-oriented economy is interspersed with many such stories of first-generation entrepreneurs taking risky bets. So, what changed in the last two decades or so?

One hypothesis is that for someone inheriting a successful business, the calculation reverses.

The special session is scheduled to begin on April 16. Yet till now, there has been no official proposal shared with MPs on what exactly the government wants the session to consider. It appears that some formula for delimitation is being suggested. Any delimitation must be preceded by a Census exercise as in the past. And it goes without saying that any delimitation involving an increase in the strength of the Lok Sabha must be politically – and not just arithmetically – equitable. States that have been pioneers in family planning, and smaller States, must not be placed at an absolute or relative disadvantage.

A proportionate increase may, in fact, result in the loss of relative influence because the difference in absolute numbers get magnified.

Need for careful consideration

The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023 provides for reservation within reservation. This means that the one-third of seats reserved for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes respectively will also be reserved for women.

During the debate in September 2023, the Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha had demanded that a similar reservation be also provided for women belonging to the Other Backward Classes (OBCs). Reservation for OBCs has been already provided for in higher education and government employment.

The monsoon session of Parliament will begin in mid-July. The heavens will not fall if the government were to call an all-party meeting after April 29, to discuss its proposals with the Opposition, allowing time for a public debate, and then have the Constitution Amendment Bills considered in the monsoon session. There is simply no justification, except narrative management during troubled times, for this tearing hurry to bulldoze extremely far-reaching changes to our polity. The process is deeply flawed and anti-democratic. Reservation for women is not the issue here. That has already been settled. The real issue is delimitation which, based on the information unofficially available, is extremely dangerous and an assault on the Constitution itself.

Risk is no longer the source of differentiation. It is a threat to something already secured. Moreover, there are more avenues for being a passive investor, such as a venture capitalist or a limited partner. Then, how can India’s private sector be incentivised to invest in R&D?

Oswald Spengler made a distinction that feels relevant here, though he was writing about civilisational cycles rather than emerging economies. He argued that societies move from what he called ‘culture’ to ‘civilisation’. Culture is rooted, productive, and comfortable with risk because it is still building foundational institutions. Civilisation is abstract, financial, and focused on administering and extracting value from what already exists. The pattern he describes maps uncomfortably well onto what is happening among India’s urban business elite. Increasingly, wealth is held by people who think like portfolio managers rather than operators. Their assets are internationally diversified. Their downside is cushioned by family networks and political connections. They sell, diversify, and preserve. However, the aggregate outcome is a business elite that no longer behaves like it has skin in the game over generational time horizons.

India’s dilemma

The problem is not that India lacks entrepreneurs. First-generation founders are still emerging and taking risks. The problem is that the inherited elite, the people who control the most capital and have the most institutional access, are opting out of the riskiest, and most transformational kinds of building. Anthony Patch’s tragedy was that his inheritance arrived after he had lost the capacity to use it. India now has an inheritance class that receives wealth and position early enough to use it, but chooses not to, because the social structures that would make risk-taking rational have been replaced by ones that make waiting and selling more attractive.

The question, then, is not whether India has capital. The question is whether the people who control that capital still see themselves as builders of something larger than their own portfolio returns. And if they do not, what does that mean for the kind of economy India becomes over the next several decades?

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The Moon moment

The successful splash down of the Artemis II mission capsule, Orion, in the Pacific Ocean marked a defining milestone in NASA’s collaborative deep space endeavours. The 10-day challenging space voyage has scripted a historic return of humans to the lunar flyby after more than five decades since they last ventured there. The enduring legacy of the Artemis II mission lies not only in the vital scientific data it gathered, but also in awakening the dreams of

young students. The insights from the Artemis II mission also holds pivotal relevance for the ISRO in the context of India’s upcoming human spaceflight mission, Gaganyaan.

G. Ramasubramanyam
Vijayawada

Deadlock in Islamabad

The much anticipated peace talks between the U.S and Iran in Islamabad have failed to yield a meaningful outcome, as both sides continue to remain entrenched in their

respective positions. A key impediment to progress is the ongoing conflict in Lebanon, where Israel’s military actions have drawn strong objections from Iran. In this context, the U.S. must play a constructive role by urging Israel to de-escalate tensions and cease hostilities.

M. Jeyaram
Tamil Nadu

Unity in diversity

The idea of a Uniform Civil Code (UCC) resurfaces prominently during elections. While its objective

of ensuring equality and justice is commendable, India’s vast diversity cannot be ignored. The country is home to multiple religions. Given this complexity, any move towards UCC must be cautious and inclusive. The Central government should constitute a broad-based committee comprising not just politicians, but also intellectuals, social workers, and representatives from religious and tribal communities. Such a body must deliberate thoroughly on sensitive issues and

propose balanced solutions.
T. Kailash Ditya
Hyderabad

Epic comeback

Chennai Super Kings delivered a vintage performance against Delhi Capitals, staging a remarkable comeback when it mattered most. This emphatic victory not only revived their campaign but also injected a fresh wave of confidence and belief into the side. This memorable win, achieved at a crucial stage of the tournament, will be cherished by fans

and could well serve as the spark the CSK needs to reignite their campaign in this edition of the IPL.

A.P. Thiruvadi
Chennai



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Tapping fisheries in reservoirs

Budget 2026-27 highlights undertaking of initiatives for integrated development of fisheries in 500 reservoirs and Amrit Sarovars (ponds developed under Mission Amrit Sarovar) to enhance income of fish farmers. This will also involve strengthening market access to fish farmer-producer organisations and cooperatives.

India is the second largest fish producer in the world. Now, it is also the second largest globally in aquaculture production. The country has witnessed a 106% increase in the national fish production since 2013-14 that stands at a record 197.75 lakh tonnes in 2024-25. Interestingly, 75% of our fish production comes from inland fisheries that include freshwater, brackish, and saline water resources. Reservoirs, spread over an area of more than 31.50 lakh hectares, are a major source of freshwater fisheries and aquaculture. Fish production from these water bodies is approximately 18 lakh tonnes.

Located primarily in eastern, central and the peninsular regions, these reservoirs contribute to the livelihood of millions of fish farmers. This is especially true for economically backward and water-scarce regions where they play a crucial role in providing direct/indirect employment and food security.

While Madhya Pradesh has the maximum area under reservoirs (about six lakh hectares), Tamil Nadu has the highest number of reservoirs at over 8,000.

A key factor in the rise of the country's fish production is the increase in fish productivity in reservoirs to 100 kg per hectare compared to 50 kg in 2006. This has been made possible by application of cage culture technology with sufficient stocking of quality seed backed by requisite budgetary support under flagship programmes such as Blue Revolution (BR) and the Pradhan Mantri Matsya Sampada Yojana (PMMSY). While the Indian major



Abhilaksh Likhi

Union Secretary,
Department of
Fisheries,
Government of India

carps (Catla, Rohu, Mrigal) form the core species for stocking, need-based stocking of additional species (Tilapia, Pangasius, etc.), in consultation with beneficiaries, is provided under the above programmes.

These reservoir cages, floating or stationary, are typically made of synthetic netting or mesh with a structure for support. The mesh allows for natural water flow, ensuring oxygen and nutrient exchange with the surrounding environment. These cages are anchored to the bottom or suspended from buoys to maintain their position and depth. This facilitates easier feeding, monitoring, and disease management. Further, to promote species diversification, in addition to rectangular cages, circular cages are increasingly being deployed.

Bimal Chandra Oran is a fish farmer from Saraikela district in Jharkhand who has taken up aquaculture for his livelihood in the Chandil reservoir ecosystem. As a member of the Chandil Bandh Visthapit Matsyajibhi Swalambhi Sahkar Samiti (CBVMSS), he set up two cages and was provided subsidised seed and feed inputs. This was followed by a series of capacity-building trainings to upgrade his skills. Over the years, he has cultured Tilapia and Pangasius species through the reservoir cage technology. Backed by marketing support through cooperative society, he has been able to produce three tonnes of fish, thereby achieving an annual turnover of more than ₹3 lakh.

An Indian Council of Agricultural Research (ICAR)-Central Institute of Inland Fisheries (CIFRI) study envisions that aquaculture productivity can go up to 300 kg from the current 100 kg per hectare in such reservoirs. To achieve this potential, experts suggest adopting a value chain approach through the integrated development of these reservoirs. This includes converged setting up

of hatcheries, feed mills, storage sheds, ice plants, berthing platforms, auction centres, and marketing retail outlets, and ensuring availability of boats and refrigerated trucks.

To ground the above value chain approach, a cluster-based strategy is being implemented by the National Fisheries Development Board (NFDB) to enhance the competitiveness of the reservoir ecosystem through end-to-end solutions. In line with this strategy, recently a reservoir cluster has been announced for the Halalai and Indra Sagar dams in Madhya Pradesh. The effort will be, first and foremost, to identify sectoral gaps in fisheries production, productivity, and processing capacities within this reservoir ecosystem. Critical, for instance, herein will be the assessment of multiplicity of agencies owning fishing rights, which sometimes poses challenges in data gathering. And without doubt, it will also entail enhancing economies of scale for local fish farmers by their aggregation through cooperatives and fish farmer-producer organisations. Such reservoir clusters will be replicated in other States and Union Territories as well.

In addition, Mission Amrit Sarovar is being implemented with the core vision of conserving surface and underground water in district ponds. A key innovation herein is mapping of user groups for pond management through community participation. Each Amrit Sarovar is designed to have a pondage area of minimum one acre with a holding capacity of 10,000 cubic metres. The Amrit Sarovar at Dine Dite Rijo in Upper Subansiri district of Arunachal Pradesh is a success story of a retention basin that has been successfully used for stocking and aquaculture of ornamental fishes. Tapping fisheries in reservoirs and Amrit Sarovars aligns with the Viksit Bharat@2047 vision to empower fishermen families to thrive and contribute to the nation's Blue Revolution.

State of contrasts

Karnataka's growth continues to be marked by sharp inter-district disparities

STATE OF PLAY

Nagesh Prabhu
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A report tabled in the Karnataka legislature during the Budget Session has reignited the debate on persistent regional imbalances in the State. Karnataka's growth story continues to be marked by sharp inter-district disparities, with divergence of key economic indicators widening over the years.

Characterised as a "State of contrasts", Karnataka has recorded strong growth over the years (8.1% in 2025-26). However, this has not translated into economic convergence among districts. Growth remains concentrated in a few districts, while most continue to lag. Despite the State ranking second in Goods and Services Tax collection after Maharashtra and emerging as a hub of technology, innovation, and startups, its economic activity is largely confined to Bengaluru, besides the growth in the coastal districts of Dakshina Kannada and Udupi and the coffee-growing regions of the Western Ghats.

The 2026 report on regional imbalances, tabled by a committee headed by noted economist M. Govinda Rao, paints a stark picture. Of the State's 236 taluks, 177 have been classified as backward, including 59 as most backward, 59 as more backward, and 59 as backward. Only 59 taluks are categorised as developed. The share of backward taluks has risen from 65% (114 of 175 taluks) in 2001-02 to 72.8% in 2022-23. Of the 59 more backward taluks, 43 are in north Karnataka and only 16 are in south Karnataka, underlining the widening regional disparities despite overall

economic progress.

Over the past two decades, the government has spent ₹35,380.24 crore on infrastructure development in backward taluks. However, there has been limited improvement in outcomes due to "lack of prioritisation of projects and schemes with large social rates of return" and inefficiencies in the functioning of regional development boards – pointing to a serious administrative failure.

Within north Karnataka, Kalaburagi division accounts for the largest share (42%) of most backward taluks. This region, now known as Kalyana Karnataka (formerly Hyderabad-Karnataka), enjoys a special status under Article 371J of the Constitution since 2013.

Further, the committee's analysis of the growth trajectories of different districts over the years indicates slow improvement of districts in north Karnataka and dramatic growth in Bengaluru and coastal districts. Inequality in per capita income remains stark. According to the State's Economic Survey (2025-26), Bengaluru Urban leads with a per capita income of ₹8,55,960, followed by Dakshina Kannada (₹6,26,279), Udupi (₹6,00,683), Chikkamagaluru (₹4,94,787) and Shivamogga (₹3,89,743) – all above the State average of ₹3,86,156 in 2024-25. In contrast, Kalyana Karnataka and Kittur Karnataka in North Karnataka have re-

corded significantly lower figures at ₹189,938 and ₹226,213, respectively.

Karnataka's industrialisation and service-sector expansion have remained overwhelmingly Bengaluru-centric. Bengaluru and its periphery, which contribute nearly 40% to the State's Gross State Domestic Product, are home to many Fortune 500 companies and have skilled manpower for various sectors and elite public institutions. While coastal districts are recognised as the 'cradle of Indian banking' and have grown through private entrepreneurship, the Mysuru region has grown through relatively better infrastructure, irrigation, education, and connectivity.

This widening gap reflects the fact that a high percentage of the population in the north Karnataka region still depends on the agriculture sector, and 'new economy' sectors are yet to emerge here on a large scale. The recent protests by government job aspirants in Dharwad in north Karnataka underscore the lack of alternative employment opportunities. More than two decades ago, the D.M. Nanjundappa Committee (2002) found that north Karnataka was under-represented in public sector jobs (34.84%), while south Karnataka accounted for a dominant share (65.16%).

Increased spending alone may not suffice to spur growth. Multiple studies have argued that addressing regional disparities will require a bottom-up development approach, greater decentralisation, and stronger accountability. Sustained and balanced growth will depend on targeted investments in education, healthcare, and infrastructure, backed by responsive governance.

Poll-bound T.N. among top performers in many indicators

The State's performance exceeds the national average across various social and education-related indicators; however, it is a mixed bag in other indicators

DATA POINT

Sambavi Parthasarathy

Tamil Nadu is going to polls on April 23 and political parties have made a slew of promises, many of them having women and education at their centre. At this point, an indicator-based analysis shows that though the State remains a frontrunner on several economic, educational and women-related indicators, concerns remain.

Firstly, Tamil Nadu recorded a Human Development Index score of 0.787 in 2023, higher than the national average. This indicator, as defined by the United Nations Development Programme, is a summary measure of average achievement in key dimensions of human development such as life expectancy, education, and standard of living. (Table 1).

Data shows that Tamil Nadu is strong across various economic indicators. For select indicators such as the per capita net domestic product – the net average income earned by an individual in the State at a certain period – and average daily wage rates in rural areas, Tamil Nadu's figures remain much higher than India's average. In fact, with an average daily wage rate of ₹573.2 in rural areas, the State's wages are the highest among others with the exception of Kerala.

Tamil Nadu's debt-to-GSDP ratio in 2023-24, as per the latest Finance Commission report, stood at 29.9%. However, the State's GSDP growth rate of 11.9% during 2024-25, the highest among all States, is likely to improve its fiscal indicators.

While the State performed well across many health and women-related indicators, it lagged in areas such as sanitation and health scheme coverage (Table 2). It is one of the five top performing States across several health indicators related to children and wo-

men. According to Niti Aayog, its maternal mortality ratio is 54 per lakh live births, far lower than the national average of 97.

A similar pattern can be seen for indicators related to children too. As of 2023, the State's infant mortality rate is 12 per thousand children, nearly half of India's average. It is also the fourth State to have the least share of children aged 0-5 with stunted growth. It ranks second when it comes to share of children with all basic vaccinations (%).

Though 66.5% of the surveyed households had at least one member covered by a health scheme, Tamil Nadu lags behind seven other States in this indicator. The share of population in the State remaining with unimproved sanitation facilities was also higher than the national average.

Tamil Nadu is also a frontrunner when it comes to education-related indicators (Table 3). The State ranks among the top-performing States for Adjusted Net Enrolment Rate (ANER) in elementary education – the number of pupils of school-age group for primary education, enrolled either in primary or secondary education as a share of the total population in that age group.

Tamil Nadu also has the third lowest dropout rate among the States. Further, the State's Gross Enrolment Ratio in higher secondary education is much higher than the all India average. However, the State ranked 16 among 29 States when it came to the Gender Parity Index in higher education – the ratio of female to male students enrolled at a specific level of education.

However, the State lagged on select environment-related indicators (Table 4). It was among the top seven States that generated high amounts of plastic waste per thousand population and consumed high levels of fossil fuels per capita.

(With inputs from Nitika Francis and Devyanshi Bihani)



In the fray: Campaign materials on display ahead of Assembly election. RAGU R.

Tracking progress

The data for the tables are sourced from the NFHS (2021-22), NITI Aayog, Global Data Lab, Economic Survey 2024-25 and Parliament Q&A

Table 1: Tamil Nadu's values and ranks in terms of Human Development Index and select economic indicators

Indicator	Tamil Nadu's Value	Tamil Nadu's Rank (Out of 29)	India Average	Top performing States/UTs
Human Development Index (2023)	0.787	10	0.732	Goa (0.862), Kerala (0.860), New Delhi (0.837)
Per capita NSDP, current prices (2024-25)(₹)	361,619	4	205,324	Delhi (4,93,024), Telangana (3,87,623), Karnataka (3,80,906)
Average daily wage rates in rural areas (₹)	573.2	2	398	Kerala (868.7), Tamil Nadu (573.2), Himachal Pradesh (516)

Table 2: Tamil Nadu's values and ranks across select indicators related to health and women

Indicator	Tamil Nadu's Value	Rank (Out of 30)	India Average	Top performing States/UTs
Share of women aged 15-19 who have begun childbearing (%)	6.3%	19	6.80%	Uttarakhand (2.4%), Kerala (2.4%), Goa (2.7%)
Infant mortality rate	12	6	25	Kerala (4.4), Goa (5.6), Sikkim (11.2)
Share of population with unimproved sanitation facility (%)	21.7%	23	19.3%	Mizoram (0.1%), Kerala (0.2%), Sikkim (0.3%)
Share of children aged 0-5 years whose growth is stunted (%)	25%	4	36%	Sikkim (22%), Kerala (23%), Manipur (23%)
Percentage of children with all basic vaccinations (%)	89%	2	77%	Odisha (91%), Tamil Nadu (89%), Himachal Pradesh (89%)
Women using a hygienic method of menstrual protection (%)	98.4%	1	77.6%	Tamil Nadu (98.4%), Kerala (93.3%), Punjab (93.3%)
Maternal Mortality Ratio (per 1,00,000 live births)	54	5	97	Kerala (19), Maharashtra (33), Telangana (43)
Households with at least one member covered by a health scheme (%)	66.5%	8	41%	Rajasthan (87.8%), Andhra Pradesh (80.2%), Goa (73.1%)

Table 3: Tamil Nadu's values and ranks across select indicators related to education out of 29 States

Indicator	Tamil Nadu's Value	Tamil Nadu's Rank	India Average	Top Performing States/UTs
Dropout rate	4.5%	3	12.6%	Manipur (1.3%), Himachal Pradesh (1.5%), Tamil Nadu (4.5%)
Adjusted Net Enrolment Rate (ANER) in elementary education (%)	99.5%	2	96.5%	Multiple States (100%), Tamil Nadu (99.5%), Punjab (99.2%)
Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in higher secondary (%)	81.50%	5	57.6%	Delhi (94.9%), Himachal Pradesh (94.1%), Kerala (85%)
Gender Parity Index (GPI) for higher education	1.01	16	N/A	Kerala (1.44), Himachal Pradesh (1.33), Nagaland (1.28)

Table 4: Tamil Nadu's values and ranks across select indicators related to environment

Indicator	Tamil Nadu's Value	Tamil Nadu's Rank	India Average	Top Performing States/UTs
Plastic waste generated per 1,000 population (tonnes/annum)	5.64	5 out of 23	3.04	Goa (18.9), Delhi (16.9), Telangana (12.5)
Per capita fossil fuel consumption (in kg.)	200.75	7	166.43	Haryana (341.9), Gujarat (339.2), H.P. (271.7)

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO APRIL 13, 1976

Hydrogeological map to be compiled

Madras, April 12: The Central Groundwater Board is compiling a hydrogeological map of India to be presented at the 25th International Geological Congress in Sydney. This map will be drawn on a scale 1:5,000,000. Under the international hydrological decade programme, 700 hydrograph stations have been selected to monitor seasonal water levels from different geological formations under known hydrogeological settings.

For the first time on a national scale, the Board has undertaken systematic search for locating groundwater. It has so far covered over a million sq.km. out of a total estimated area of 3.2 million sq.km. Data collected by these stations on water level fluctuations and temperature variations covers over 60 per cent of unexplored area in the country. Over 5,000 short term water supply investigations in drought prone areas have been completed. These are confined to small isolated pockets and resulted in setting up of new hydrogeological horizons.

The Board has undertaken special investigations for locating and investigating thermal springs, mines and coalfields to spot out inland salinity of groundwater in these areas.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO APRIL 12, 1926

America spends £2,900 millions yearly on motors

The American Bureau of Industrial Technology announces that America's motoring bill exceeded £2,800,000,000 last year. Four million motor-cars are now manufactured in America yearly, a quarter of a million cars are exported and the remainder are bought by Americans at an average price, including accessories, of £200. It costs the average American £140 annually to run his car. The following table shows America's total motor-car expenditure in million pounds:— Cost of cars and accessories 750; depreciation 500; upkeep and repairs 400; chauffeurs' wages 320; petrol 240; garages 180; taxes 125; tyres 123; interest on investment 100; oil 50; insurance 60. The total is 2,853 million pounds. — "The Statesman."

(The Hindu did not have an edition on April 13, 1926)

M CH-CHE

ASSEMBLY POLLS

AJP candidate summoned by police in Assam

▼ The Assam Jatiya Parishad on Sunday slammed Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma after its candidate for Guwahati Central Kunki Chowdhury was summoned by the police in an election-related case and claimed that the ruling party was rattled after seeing that the mandate has gone against

it in the constituency. Ms. Chowdhury reached the Panbazar Police Station in the morning after receiving a summons. A case was filed against her and her campaign manager, Sandeep Yadav, by a BJP activist Naba Kumar Lahkar on April 9, alleging the duo violated the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) The AJP has strongly condemned the “harassment” of its candidate by the police, and has lodged a formal complaint with the Chief Electoral Officer of Assam. PTI



AJP leader Kunki Chowdhury after casting her vote in Guwahati on Thursday. ANI

Over 3.6 crore to vote in Phase 1 in Bengal: EC

▼ More than 3.6 crore electors across 16 districts are eligible to exercise their franchise in the first phase of the West Bengal Assembly election on April 23, according to Election Commission data. The electoral rolls for the first phase have 1.84 crore men, 1.75 crore women and 465 persons of the third

gender, the EC data released on Saturday showed. Among the districts, Murshidabad accounts for the highest number of voters with 50.26 lakh, followed by Purba Medinipur (41.6 lakh) and Paschim Medinipur (37.7 lakh). At the other end, Kalimpong has the lowest number of voters at 2.01 lakh. An EC official said the electoral rolls have been “updated after due revision and verification to ensure maximum accuracy and inclusiveness”. PTI



Today, we have modern-day reincarnations of Dyer and Curzon sitting in Delhi and trying to rule Bengal through remote control
ABHISHEK BANERJEE
Trinamool Congress leader

NIA detains seven in Malda gherao case

▼ The NIA on Sunday detained seven people, including a Congress candidate, and arrested a panchayat member of the ISF over the gherao of judicial officers by locals in Malda protesting the deletion of names in the SIR exercise, an officer said. The NIA has been tasked with probing the April 1 incident. PTI



Tamil people will never allow communal mobs to occupy Tamil fortress nurtured by Periyar, Annadurai, Karunanidhi, and BJP has realised this
M.K. STALIN
Chief Minister and DMK leader



Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's grand nephew, Chandra Kumar Bose, joined the Trinamool Congress in the presence of senior leaders. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Netaji's grand nephew Chandra Bose joins Trinamool ahead of polls

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's grand nephew Chandra Kumar Bose, who quit the Bharatiya Janata Party in 2023, joined the Trinamool Congress on Sunday. Mr. Bose said his earlier decision to join the BJP was a “historic mistake”. “A few years ago, I made a historic mistake by being a part of the BJP. I rectified that mistake by joining the Trinamool, because with Bengal's history, tradition and culture, there are no similarities with the BJP,” Mr. Chandra Bose said. In the recent months, Mr. Chandra Bose had been critical of the special intensive revision (SIR) process in West Bengal.

Slams BJP's politics

He said the BJP did not believe in Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose's principles and it was not possible to work with Netaji's vision because the BJP did not allow him. “What we are seeing today is communal hatred, division led by the BJP. This time, there is a fight to save India and stop this divisive politics. The time has come,” Mr. Chandra Bose said.

He joined the Trinamool in the presence of senior leaders such as Bratya Basu and Kirti Azad.

His induction into the Trinamool comes at a crucial time just days ahead of the high-stakes Assembly election in West Bengal on April 23 and 29.

Mr. Bratya Basu, State Education Minister, said, “In the BJP's language, this is *ghar wapsi*. A secular person has returned to a secular place.”

'Ideological differences'

Mr. Chandra Bose contested the 2019 Lok Sabha election on BJP ticket from Rashbehari. He had joined the BJP in 2016 and parted ways with it in 2023 over “ideological differences”. Since then, on multiple occasions, he had been vocal about his disagreements with the BJP ideology. After the publication of the voter list in Bengal, Mr. Chandra Bose, on his social media handle, asked why the civil society of the State was not protesting against the exclusion of 90 lakh voters. He also questioned the role of the Election Commission, and accused it of failing to stay “free and fair” ahead of the election. Earlier, the late Krishna Bose and her son and historian Sugata Bose had represented the Trinamool in Parliament. Both of them are members of the Netaji Subhash Chandra Bose family.

CARTOONSCAPE | MIKA AZIZ



CAMPAIGN TRAIL

The Hindu Bureau
RAMANATHAPURAM

BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Sunday accused the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam government in Tamil Nadu of “prioritising the exploitation of the resources of the poor over actual development of the State”. He was addressing a public meeting in front of the Ramanathapuram Palace in support of the BJP's candidate for the Ramanathapuram constituency, ‘GBS’ K. Nagendran.

“The DMK and Congress are pushing Tamil Nadu into a state of poverty through corruption. Once an NDA government is established in Tamil Nadu, it will put an end to the drug culture in the State,” he said.

He said the current Ramanathapuram MLA had encouraged corruption and drug culture in the district. “The Union government is building houses for the poor across the country. The DMK government has built up a debt of ₹10 lakh crore. People must ask whether they used this money to build houses or roads,” he said.

Targeting the DMK over

the law and order situation, he said the State government had failed to act even as more than 8,900 people were murdered in Tamil Nadu.

Illicit liquor deaths

Recalling deaths in Kallakurichi district due to the consumption of illicit liquor, he charged that Chief Minister M.K. Stalin did not even go there to offer condolences to the 68 families who lost their kin. On the Thiruparankundram row, he said, “Despite the High Court's order, the Tamil Nadu government did not allow the lighting of the lamp atop the Thiruparankundram hill. To punish the DMK government for this, you must vote for the NDA on April 23. When Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin spoke against *Sanatana Dharma*, senior Congress leader Rahul Gandhi did not condemn it. In Tamil Nadu, Rameswaram and the Madurai Meenakshi Amman Temple are sacred lands. But the DMK government speaks mockingly of *Sanatana Dharma*”.

Mr. Nabin accused the DMK government of looting the money of the poor without worrying about the State's development. “It is turning Tamil Nadu into the number one state



Ground zero: BJP national president Nitin Nabin at a roadshow for BJP State president and Sattur candidate Nainar Nagenthiran on Sunday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

in corruption. Due to corruption, five lakh job opportunities have been blocked,” he alleged. “They have engaged in corruption worth ₹5,000 crore through employment scams and tens of thousands of crores through TASMAL [the State liquor firm],” he noted.

Pledging to bring an end to the “family rule” in Tamil Nadu, he stated that the government was working only for the family of Mr. Stalin.

“For a DMK worker, becoming the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister is a pipe dream. This family rule must be abolished. The DMK government should be thrown out on May 4. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has provided thousands of crores in funds for the development of Tamil Nadu. Specifically, he provided ₹4,000 crore for Madurai and around ₹5,000 crore for Tiruchi. If you vote for the NDA, Tamil Nadu will be taken

along the path of progress,” he claimed. Importance will be given to Rameswaram just like Kashi, he stated, while adding, “The holy waters of Rameswaram's Agni Theertham are being contaminated with sewage.” By not properly implementing the Jal Jeevan scheme, the DMK government had committed irregularities, which had made clean drinking water a distant dream in the district. “During the Iran war, the

Prime Minister rescued over 700 of our fishermen, including 50 from Ramanathapuram district who were stranded in Iran. Our Prime Minister protects not only the people of the country but also the people outside the country,” he added.

BJP's election co-in-charge for Tamil Nadu Sudhakar Reddy, BJP national general council member and actor R. Sarath Kumar, and BJP district president Muralidharan, among others, were present.

Warm welcome

Mr. Nabin also hit the roads in Sattur town in Virudhunagar district seeking votes for the party's State president and Sattur candidate Nainar Nagenthiran. Mr. Nabin began his roadshow from Madurai Road, along with Mr. Nagenthiran and Mr. Sarath Kumar. The vehicle wound through the arterial roads, passing by the bus stand and taluk office, before concluding at Mukkuranthal.

Mr. Nabin displayed the ‘Lotus’ symbol and waved at the crowd of BJP cadre and workers of alliance parties.

The crowd gave a warm welcome to the BJP national president by showering petals. The roadshow went on for around 30 minutes.

Bengal CM says BJP plans to divide State using delimitation

Shrabana Chatterjee
KOLKATA

West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee alleged on Sunday that the Bharatiya Janata Party government at the Centre wanted to carry out a delimitation exercise to trifurcate the State and change the demographic and geographical composition of the province.

“Through delimitation, they might merge some districts of Bengal with Bihar and Odisha. People will face even more suffering. Our government will not allow the formation of detention camps,” Ms. Banerjee said during a public rally in Bankura. She added that the people of Bengal are likely to face major hardships if the BJP is voted to power.

Decisive moment

She positioned the election as a decisive moment in Bengal politics calling it a “do-or-die” situation, which will decide the fate of the State. She alleged that the BJP had struck a ₹1,000-crore deal (with Trinamool Congress defector Humayun Kabir) to conspire and overthrow the Trinamool government in the State. Her comments are in refe-



Mamata Banerjee

rence to an alleged viral video of the Aam Janata Unayan Party chief. According to the Trinamool, the leader was seen making a deal with the BJP to mislead Muslims in the State.

At another rally on Sunday, at Khandagosh in Purba Bardhaman, she sharpened her criticism of the wrongful deletions of voters, and said that it was part of a broader political move by the BJP, which was trying to introduce the National Register for Citizens (NRC) via the backdoor, and said that it would leave people without “identity, land or household”.

She warned voters about vote tampering, and asked people to stay vigilant, and to check EVMS for foul play before casting their votes.

All the BJP candidates in Bengal Assembly polls are Modi: PM in Siliguri rally

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Taking a leaf out of West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's campaign book, Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday said that all Bharatiya Janata Party candidates contesting the Assembly election were “Modi”.

“You all are Modi for me. All these candidates are also Modi. In the past 70 years, you gave everyone a chance, you gave the Congress a chance, you gave the Trinamool a chance. Now give Modi a chance,” the Prime Minister said at a public meeting at Siliguri in Darjeeling district.

BJP candidates contesting the polls from Darjeeling, Kalimpong and Jalpaiguri districts were present during his address. The Prime Minister asked them to present themselves on the stage and urged people to vote for them.

During her campaign, Ms. Banerjee has stated in several rallies that “she is the Trinamool candidate for all the 294 seats” and that the people should vote thinking about her and not the individual candidates.

The Prime Minister at



Canvassing for votes: Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other BJP leaders during a public meeting in Siliguri on Sunday. PTI

public rallies on Sunday appealed to voters to give “one chance to Modi for the safety of Bengal's daughters, one chance to Modi to protect Bengal from infiltration, one chance to Modi to ensure that Bengal's youth get jobs within Bengal itself, and one chance to Modi to bring back industries”.

Strategic importance

Emphasising the strategic importance of the Siliguri Corridor, the Prime Minister said that Trinamool supports the “*tukde-tukde*” gang (people who want to break India) that had threatened to snap the strategic corridor to cut off North-east India from the rest of the country.

“For the BJP, the Siliguri Corridor is the corridor of

security and prosperity of the country. We are constantly trying for its development,” Mr. Modi told the rally.

The Prime Minister alleged that the Trinamool has deliberately kept north Bengal behind and raised the issue of devastation caused by floods in the region last year.

Mr. Modi also targeted the Trinamool for “appeasement policies” and said that these policies were causing major demographic changes in the region.

“It will be too late if the infiltration menace is not stopped right away,” the Prime Minister said, coining a new slogan – “*Kamal khilao, ghuspetia bhagao*” (Vote for lotus and drive infiltrators away).

BJP will bring inclusive govt. in Bengal, says Adityanath

Press Trust of India
SONAMUKHI

Accusing the Trinamool Congress of pursuing appeasement policies in West Bengal, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Sunday urged people to vote for a “double-engine” government here to bring in “a truly inclusive regime”.

Addressing a rally at Sonamukhi in Bankura district, Mr. Adityanath said Bengal was known as the land of Swami Vivekananda and Ramakrishna, who enriched the country's spiritual quest.

“But the Trinamool government disrespects spiritual icons,” he alleged. “Bengal has now become the place of ‘*goonda gardi*’, which was common in Uttar Pradesh nine-to-10 years back before the BJP came to power there. But see the changes now,” he added.

He said there was no appeasement in Uttar Pradesh, but “inclusive Hinduism”, where every community can live peacefully in a secure environment. During the Trinamool regime, demographic changes had taken place in Bengal because of infiltration. “The BJP will protect the State's identity and safeguard its inclusive character,” he said.

No, life insurance isn't like fixed deposit

COVERNOTE

K. Nitya Kalyani

In the previous instalment of CoverNote we saw an idea of what constitutes mis-selling. How does it happen? How do you get mis-led about the nature and suitability of an insurance policy?

Insurance spells safety. A policy's features contribute to providing you security. It will also have some features you have to be aware of before you buy. When those are understated, not clarified, or even hidden from you or misrepresented, it makes the product sound safer than it is and lulls you into the purchase.

The mis-selling sales pitch is tuned to make an insurance policy sound benign, simple and more advantageous than it is.

Common and vintage tactics to mis-sell start with describing a life insurance policy as 'like a fixed deposit'. It isn't and cannot be. Many life policies are sold as offering 'guaranteed' returns. Some returns may be guaranteed under some policies, but many are declared year to year and are dependent on various terms and conditions.

Cousins of the guaranteed return are the minimum return and the assured addition. They may apply only to part of the proceeds of the policy while others are variable and optional.

Another ploy is to position the mandatory illustrative benefits as guaranteed. The difference between the two will be clearly printed in the policy brochure and you should ensure you ask for it apart from hearing the oral pitch which can be misleading.

Unit-linked insurance policies (ULIPs) are sold as high return policies and better than mutual funds as they come with life coverage. The high returns are a possibility indeed, as are low returns or losses! As for their comparison with mutual funds, please ask for a comparable fund option and check for yourself what the charges are on the ULIP and on the mutual fund.

Selling a regular premium policy as a single premium has become the saddest and most laughable kind of mis-selling. And then there is pressure sales of insurance as a tax-saver. Yes, that same one you were subjected to all of last month!

More serious cases involve underplaying facts that are material to the policy and its coverage. Let us say you declare a pre-existing disease (PED). The agent may persuade you to avoid this since coverage would be difficult or premium would be higher. Or you may make it easy for him, like many do, by signing a blank proposal form that he can complete ethically or unethically.

There are sinister cases where signatures have been forged on cleaned up versions of proposal forms and even fake lab test reports showing safe blood glucose levels and normal ECGs have been substituted to hide PEDs.

The proposal and its declarations are yours to live with and so are the claims denials that will haunt you later on. You can prevent this entirely by filling up your proposal form personally and retaining a photocopy. And there is a second chance to correct any error or mischief. When the insurance policy is issued to you, the company has to give you a copy of your proposal form. It is in your interest to check it at least then. The 15-day free-look period when you can return any policy and get a refund of premium is an opportunity to exit a bad deal. I would urge you strongly to be aware of it and be ready to use it if needed. Like many things in this world, for each unethical seller there are many more honest foot-soldiers in the insurance sales army. The sad news is that academic studies in marketing reveal that mis-sellers make more money, for themselves and their companies.

That was a sample of how mis-selling can happen. Let's go on to see why and what you can do to protect yourself as indeed the regulator's position.

(The writer is a business journalist specialising in insurance & corporate history)



Sneaky disorder: Much like physical health, an outwardly comfortable lifestyle and generous spending can be deceptive. ILLUSTRATION: P. SAINATH

Diagnose financial health at home with these vitals

Just as blood tests and scans help in understanding physical health, a set of financial “vitals” can reveal the true state of one’s fiscal well-being

FINOSIS SCORE

Vaishali R. Venkat

Often, we hear allopathic doctors say, “Numbers don’t lie.” Perhaps, those words hold true in a broad sense, though occasional hiccups, misleading readings, inaccuracies, or even false reports cannot be entirely ruled out. By and large, a routine health check-up, with scans and blood tests, offers valuable insight into our internal well-being, even if no report is entirely flawless. In contrast, physical appearances, however healthy we may seem on the outside, cannot always reveal hidden disorders or diseases.

Much like physical health, an outwardly comfortable lifestyle and generous spending can be deceptive, creating an illusion of prosperity while masking a far more fragile financial reality beneath.

This is precisely where a financial diagnostic tool becomes invaluable. Let us now step into the world of ‘Finosis Score’, where numbers begin to tell a deeper story. Unlike medical tests conducted in laboratories by professionals, the Finosis Score, a financial health check-up tracker, can be done individually at home by examining a few key parameters.

No single test can capture complete physical or mental well-being. Similarly, no single parameter can reflect overall financial

health. Often, income, investments, and spending are only a trailer revealing just a slice of the story. The main picture emerges only from a set of underlying financial “vital” indicators that, together, reflect the true condition of one’s financial life. With this in perspective, let’s now learn how to diagnose our financial health...

For ease of understanding, the term “Finosis,” a portmanteau of ‘financial’ and ‘diagnosis,’ is being used to describe a financial health report. Often, income, investments, and spending are only a trailer revealing just a slice of the story. The main picture emerges only from a set of underlying financial “vital” indicators that, together, reflect the true condition of one’s financial life. With this in perspective, let’s now learn how to diagnose our financial health...

‘Financial Scan’ The ‘Financial Scan’ draws attention to five crucial indicators that together shape the building blocks of one’s financial profile. The parameters include: the burden of debt, the ex-

tent of risk protection through insurance coverage (health and term), the stability of income, the proportion of income set aside for investments, and the presence of a safety cushion, including owning a home and at least six months of emergency funds, to absorb unexpected shocks. Each of these elements does not operate in isolation; together, they shape whether financial strength is quietly built or gradually eroded.

For a simple self-check, each of these can be assigned a score on a scale of 0 to 10, based on how weak or strong it appears. For debt burden, inverse scoring applies: a lower burden reflects a higher health score.

In the case of risk protection, the score may be divided between health and term insurance, with up to five marks assigned to each. Similarly, for the safety cushion, the score may be divided between emergency savings and owning a home, with up to five marks assigned to each. Adding these scores offers a quick sense of where your financial strength stands and where

it may need attention. Even a quick attempt at this 50-point exercise can reveal surprising gaps or strengths in one’s financial position.

‘Behavioural Pulse’

The ‘Behavioural Pulse’ captures the hidden, often overlooked side of financial health. The five parameters include: impulse control in spending, the awareness of money flows, the fear of losing income, the fear of the future, and the effort devoted to skill development, which is the preventative medicine that keeps your income stability immune to market decay. Each of these may be assigned a score on a scale of 0 to 10. For the fear of income loss and the future, the scoring is reversed: the less fear you have, the higher your health score and vice versa.

This internal 50-point score offers a quick sense of whether one’s financial behaviour is strengthening financial stability or quietly digging one’s own financial grave. While the ‘Financial Scan’ reveals the visible picture, the ‘Behavioural Pulse’ determines how that picture evolves over a period of time. Therefore, neither can be ignored at the expense of the other.

Now that marks have been carefully assigned to all, the combined score, out of 100, acts as a mirror to overall financial health.

(The writer is an NISM & CRISIL-certified Wealth Manager and certified in NISM’s Research Analyst module)

Why SIPs on individual stocks?

THINKINVESTOR

You can choose the stocks you want to buy for your portfolio and you can also sell them whenever you want

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Fundamental analysis is best left to professional analysts. An analyst tracking, say, the automobile sector, forecasts cash flows of each company in the sector and determines its stock value. You and I cannot replicate this work as individual investors, as we cannot have in-depth understanding of all companies across sectors if we were to create a multi-sector portfolio. Professional money managers use analyst reports to create portfolios. That means it is optimal to invest in mutual funds if you prefer active products. Yet, many individuals prefer to buy individual stocks through systematic investment plans (SIP). In this article, we discuss a behavioural reason that can explain this preference.

One argument in favour of buying individual stocks instead of mutual funds is that you can choose the stocks you want to buy for your portfolio. An extension of this argument is that you can also sell the stocks whenever you want. But this argument suffers from illusion of control. Why? Whether you buy individual stocks or units in a mutual fund, you can sell your investments whenever you want to. As for the argument about picking stocks, the idea of investing in a mutual fund is that the professional money managers understand the market much better than us.

But what if you have ideological differences with a fund’s investment philosophy? Suppose you do not want to take exposure to companies that manufacture tobacco and alcohol. Or your religious practices do not allow you to invest in certain types of companies, say, banks. You can select funds that fit with your ideologies. ESG-focused funds and Shariah funds, for instance. The point is that there are funds today that meet most of your requirements. While choosing active funds is not easy, neither is selecting individual stocks to invest for your goal-based investments.

The urge to own individual stocks may be difficult to overcome. This behaviour is like the desire to own physical gold instead of financial gold. One way to moderate this desire is to yield to temptation. Select a few stocks that you want to buy and invest only a modest amount in them. This should preferably be a one-time investment, not an SIP. Your SIPs for your goal-based investments must be primarily in ETFs or in active funds. What if you already have several SIPs on individual stocks? You may have to gradually shift your SIPs to ETFs or mutual funds of your choice.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda *	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,697	2,132-2,539	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	9.50 onwards	10,501 onwards	2,100 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.50%-1% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.75 onwards	10,562 onwards	2,112 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.75 - 12.55	10,319-11,262	2,064-2,252	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	8.75-13.55	10,319-11,518	2,064-2,304	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	9.85-11.65	10,587-11,034	2,117-2,207	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.40-9.45	9,995 - 10,489	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.60-10.70	10,043 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,355 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
IDBI Bank	7.75-9.40	10,078 - 10,477	Rs 2,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	NIL
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.50 onwards	10,258 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.15 onwards	10,174 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.01-11.51	10,141 - 10,999	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.20	10,043 - 10,428	No processing fees till 31.03.2026

*0.25% interest concession for home loan borrowers, existing customers with at least 6 months relationship with bank
**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on April 8

Source: Paisabazaar.com

Send queries on personal finance and investing to the moneywise@thehindu.co.in ID. Our experts in personal finance will respond to select queries, but will not give specific recommendations for investment in a particular mutual fund, share or fixed deposit.

CAREER FAIR



Deiva Sundari P., principal, Easwari Engineering College (SRM Group), speaking on ‘Women in core engineering’ at the education fair. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Girls have the edge in landing IT sector jobs: academician

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Information Technology companies are conducting recruitment drives specifically to take young women on their rolls, Deiva Sundari P., principal, Easwari Engineering College (SRM Group), said on Sunday.

“This is to retain the diversity mix in industries. But, at the same time, these graduates are top-of-their-class and industry-ready when they pass out,” she said, while speaking on the topic, ‘Women in core engineering’, at *The Hindu* EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair ’26 at the Chennai Trade Centre in Nandambakkam in the city.

Though the requirement of women in engineering was 30% of the workforce, on the ground, they represented only 12%, she said, adding that besides girls-only recruitment drives, companies were also conducting regular campus recruitment drives.

“For the next 4-5 years, girls have better scope to land jobs. In civil and mechanical streams, girls are chosen by certain industries before they complete their second year,” she said.

“Every year, top civil engineering students are hand-picked by companies, trained to be industry-ready based on the need, and taken on board in the final year. After the first year, students are chosen based on their fundamentals and skill sets, and are put in different tracks. Second-year students solve industry problems. They even attend client reviews every week,” Ms. Deiva Sundari said.

She explained to the gathering of parents and students that the traditional, pre-COVID-19 mindset had changed now. Every industry was expecting graduates with domain knowledge and critical thinking skills. To match the needs of the industry, institutes were also evolving. They were changing their curriculum and syllabus every six months, she said.

Ms. Deiva Sundari said the global capability centres run by multinational companies paid double what IT service industries were paying, and were recruiting women mostly from civil and mechanical engineering streams. “For the creamy layer, core engineering pays much better than IT services industry. The starting salary of a core engineering graduate is ₹12 lakh at Caterpillar,” she said.

When a parent asked how Electrical and Electronics Engineering (EEE) would fare, she said it was also a good option for girls. “Every automation, manufacturing industry looks for mechanical and electrical engineers. When you automate an assembly line, you are replacing human beings with robots. For that, the first requirement would be sensors, which can be commonly designed by ECE and EEE graduates. To replace human beings, there would be a requirement for sensors that are common for ECE and EEE. As robots are deployed, robotics and automation engineers are needed there. Similarly, mechanical and AI engineers too,” she added.

When asked about the need to study coding, the academician, who has industry experience too, said every engineering student has to do coding. “No industry wants students with just one skill set. You need to have multi-disciplinary knowledge,” she said.

Event sponsors

VIT Chennai presents *The Hindu - Education Plus Career Counselling Fair 2026* is powered by Hindustan Group of Institutions, Chennai and Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology, In Association with B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science & Technology and SRM Institute of Science & Technology, Tiruchirapalli. Associate partners are Amet University, Bharath Institute of Higher Education and Research, GRT Institute of Engineering and Technology, Measi Group of Institutions, Meenakshi Academy of Higher Education & Research (MAHER), Symbiosis Skills and Professional University, Pune, The Institute of Chartered Accountants of India, Vels Institute of Science, Technology & Advanced Studies (VISTAS) and Vinayaka Mission’s Research Foundation, Chennai Campus. Banking Partner for the fair is Bank of Baroda.

Cracking JEE and NEET requires structured practice: maths expert

‘Year after year, we are seeing students who think working on answering difficult questions will automatically make them proficient in answering the easier ones. That is a fallacy,’ says Ravishankar. He asks students to practise consistently and learn from their errors rather than avoid them

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Lack of structured practice is the biggest hurdle for aspirants preparing for competitive exams such as JEE and NEET, said Ravishankar A., expert professor, Mathematics, AhaGuru, at *The Hindu* EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair 26 on Sunday.

“Year after year, we are seeing students who think practising answering difficult questions will automatically make them proficient at answering the easier ones. That is a fallacy,” he said.

Speaking about the nature of the errors students make, Mr. Ravishankar said mistakes were not limited to “silly” slips. He said conceptual gaps, application mistakes, multi-concept errors, cross-chapter application, generalisation, and many other mistakes were equally common. “Mistakes are assets, if tracked. They tell you what needs to be fixed,” he said, asking students to practice consistently and learn from their errors rather than avoid them.

Students fail more than they succeed, he said, adding that the difference was not talent alone, but systematic study. He asked students to avoid last-minute preparation, adding that studying only a week



Ravishankar A., expert professor, Mathematics, AhaGuru, speaking at *The Hindu* EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

before the exam was unlikely to yield results. “Success is the result of consistent daily study. Every day, you have to set aside time for JEE preparation to crack it,” he added.

Time management
On time management, he advised students to balance preparation with

school commitments such as projects, unit tests and PPT submissions by prioritising tasks based on urgency. “Many people think speed is important, but strong foundation comes before speed,” he said.

He also talked about the role of parents in preparing students for JEE and

NEET. “Comparing your child with other children is the single most demotivating factor,” he said. Rather than focusing only on exam outcomes, the larger goal should always be about the love of learning, he said.

Study plans
Students, he suggested,

should create weekly study plans and eventually expand them into monthly schedules based on what works best for them.

“Parents should offer only guidance and encouragement; planning should ideally be done only by students. As parents, you can gently push them to stick to their plans, but

don’t pressure them,” he said.

VIT Chennai presents *The Hindu* Education Plus Career Counselling Fair ’26, which is powered by Hindustan Group of Institutions, Chennai, and Rajalakshmi Institute of Technology, in association with B.S. Abdur Rahman Crescent Institute of Science & Technology and SRM Institute of Science & Technology, Tiruchirapalli. Associate partners are Amet University, Bharath Institute of Higher Education and Research, GRT Institute of Engineering and Technology, Measi Group of Institutions, Meenakshi Academy of Higher Education & Research (MAHER), Symbiosis Skills and Professional University, Pune, the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India, Vels Institute of Science, Technology & Advanced Studies (VISTAS), and Vinayaka Mission’s Research Foundation, Chennai campus. Banking partner for the fair is Bank of Baroda.



Students should pursue core engineering subjects, says Jayaprakash Gandhi



Career consultant Jayaprakash Gandhi speaking on the topic, ‘In the age of emerging technologies’, during *The Hindu* EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair ’26 on Sunday. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Career consultant Jayaprakash Gandhi urged students to opt for core engineering subjects rather than artificial intelligence (AI) or data science-related subjects due to the more rapidly changing technology in AI and related fields.

Addressing students on the topic, ‘In the age of emerging technologies’, during the 23rd edition of the two-day *The Hindu* EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair 2026 on Sunday, he said he found it disheartening to see the student community being carried away by social media influencers in choos-

Vacancies for software engineers and code writers would diminish in the near future due to AI tools, he says

ing careers and colleges.

Social media influencers
He said the social media influencers had very little knowledge in the field of education, especially in emerging technologies. He said his advice to students would be to enrol in core engineering subjects. He highlighted various technological inventions taking place in the field of computer science.

Speaking about AI and

data science, Mr. Gandhi drew the attention of parents and students to the fact that premium educational institutions, including IIT Bombay, do not offer any AI courses.

With regard to computer science, Mr. Gandhi said vacancies for software engineers and code writers would diminish in the near future owing to AI tools.

Sharing his thoughts on the revolutionary changes happening in cyber security, mobile technology, and computer science, he explained quantum clock synchronisation system, energy-efficient computing, and the mobile technology switch-over from electron to photon.

Skills, not degrees alone, define success in today’s job market, students told

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

“The competition today is no longer between engineering students alone, but between those who possess relevant skills and those who do not; that’s how the scenario is changing,” said V. Udaya Sankar, Director, Nasscom Talent Council, and Co-Founder of Maatram Foundation. While a degree and choosing a good college remain important, acquiring the right skills is even more important, he stressed.

Mr. Sankar pointed out that companies today are no longer hiring based on degrees alone, and equal importance is being given to skill sets across domains.

Addressing students and parents on the topic, ‘Skill Development and Industry Expectations from Students’, at the 23rd edition of the two-day *The Hindu* EducationPlus Career Counselling Fair ’26 on Sunday, he said character was essential for success in today’s world, and urged students to invest in building it as the most important skill.

He also told the students that teachers were the best career counselors. “They are the strongest pillars and guiding force in one’s life, offering support without expecting anything in return,” he said.

21st-century skills
Explaining the concept of 21st-century skills – communication, collaboration, creativity, and critical thinking – he emphasised that critical



V. Udaya Sankar, Director, Nasscom Talent Council, and Co-Founder, Maatram Foundation, speaking on the topic, ‘Skill Development and Industry Expectations from Students’. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

The quality of education does not depend on the syllabus and books alone; it also relies on labs, centres of excellence, and the expertise of those who teach you

V. UDAYA SANKAR,
Director, Nasscom Talent Council, and Co-Founder of Maatram Foundation

thinking was the most important among them.

“Marks are just numbers; don’t base your life decisions on them. The quality of education does not depend on the syllabus and books alone. It also relies on labs, centres of excellence, and the exper-

tise of those who teach you. So, choose colleges with strong lab facilities, and opt for institutions that prioritise industry exposure,” Mr. Sankar said.

He also highlighted the importance of networking skills in contemporary society.

He said it was key how individuals continuously upgraded themselves, emphasising that skills defined the future. While advice about the “future trend” was common, the need was to validate such insights with industry professionals, he said.

Interacting with students, he asked how many of them believed AI would replace them, and clarified that AI will not replace humans, but those who fail to understand and adopt it.

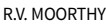
People visit stalls put up by various colleges and universities at the event at Chennai Trade Centre. B. VELANKANNI RAJ

However, just as accountants remain indispensable to using such tools, he asserted that human intelligence continues to far surpass AI.

Bumrah goes wicketless for a fourth straight game in IPL 2026



Rashid makes my life easy with the way he is bowling, says Gill



'We're not putting pressure on anyone, especially the seniors'



Shashank approached me and asked for an over, reveals Shreyas



RCB consigns MI to a third straight loss in a run-fest

Prasidh, Gill-Buttler star as Titans lord over Super Giants

Taking the pace off worked: Prasidh

Points table

	M	W	L	NR	PTS	NRR
Rajasthan Royals	4	4	0	0	8	2.055
Punjab Kings	4	3	0	1	7	0.720
Royal Challengers	4	3	1	0	6	1.148
Delhi Capitals	4	2	2	0	4	0.322
Gujarat Titans	4	2	2	0	4	-0.029
Lucknow Super Giants	4	2	2	0	4	-0.427
Sunrisers Hyderabad	4	1	3	0	2	-0.024
Mumbai Indians	4	1	3	0	2	-0.772
Chennai Super Kings	4	1	3	0	2	-1.532
Kolkata Knight Riders	4	0	3	1	1	-1.315

M CH-CH₂

SRH seeks improved bowling display

While the opening pairs Travishek and JaiSurya are capable of cutting loose in the PowerPlay, the middle-overs could well decide the contest

IPL-19
Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

Two of the IPL's most devastating opening duos are set to clash as a Sunrisers Hyderabad side blowing hot and cold hosts unbeaten Rajasthan Royals at the Rajiv Gandhi International Stadium on Monday.

Explosive duo
Travis Head and Abhishek Sharma, arguably the most explosive opening pair in T20 cricket over the past two years, once again set the tone against Punjab Kings on Friday, plundering 105 runs in the Power-Play and briefly threatening the elusive 300-run mark.
However, the pair falling in a single over and a struggling middle-order helped PBKS restrict the marauders in orange to a now modest 219.
With Pat Cummins-less

SRH pace unit went wicketless against the Kings while conceding 145 runs in 10 overs.
In contrast, the relatively inexperienced spin attack fared better with four wickets while giving away 78 runs in 8.5 overs.
Rajasthan Royals has seen SRH's Travishek and raise their own opening firebomb: JaiSurya (Yashasvi Jaiswal and Vaibhav Suryavanshi), an unintentional homage to a Lankan batting maverick by the same name.
The 383 runs between them have come at the cost of several proud bowling orders whimpering away.
Three of the season's top four run-scorers don pink and blue - the other being Dhruv Jurel.
The Royals had a forgettable 2025 with the ball, finishing with the fewest wickets (65), the worst average (42.15), and the second-highest economy rate.
This season has been good so far, with the side at

the top of the pile with 35 wickets in just four games.
A resurgent Ravi Bishnoi (nine scalps in 11 games, second in the Purple Cap standings) leads the charge.

Balanced attack
Jofra Archer and Nandre Burger with the new ball and Sandeep Sharma, Tushar Deshpande, and Ravindra Jadeja thereafter add valuable depth and discipline.
Contrasts headline this encounter. One side feeds on chaos, the other on control - and neither will want to blink first.

Today's match



Hyderabad, 7.30 p.m.

HEAD-TO-HEAD

Played: 21

SRH 12 | RR 9

PREVIOUS MEETING

SRH won by 44 runs, 2025

LIVE ON STAR SPORTS 1 & JIOTHTSTAR



Causing a flutter: Suryavanshi, who has lit up the IPL, would be eyeing another good outing.

Mental strength secret of Suryavanshi's success: Deshpande

Anirudh Velamuri
HYDERABAD

To call Vaibhav Suryavanshi the talk of the T20 circuit is quite an understatement. After showing flashes of promise last IPL, he has taken a giant leap forward this season, and the numbers reflect it emphatically.
Having scored 252 runs in seven innings in IPL 2025, he has taken just four games to reach 200 runs in this edition. His Rajasthan Royals teammate Tushar Deshpande believes the secret to his success lies in his mental strength.
"He plays the ball, not the bowler. He is quite mature for his age, which is extraordinary and some-

ing I have not seen in my cricketing career. A 15-year-old boy smashing world-class bowlers! He always has an upper hand on (the) bowlers."
Ahead of the clash against Sunrisers Hyderabad, Deshpande steered clear of comparisons between the opening pairs of both sides.
"The strengths and weaknesses are completely different. I can't bowl to Vaibhav in training as preparation to counter Travis Head.
"All four (Suryavanshi, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Head and Abhishek Sharma) are quite explosive but are different in the way they approach the game or score runs," he said.

The week ahead

April 13	SRH vs. RR	Hyderabad	7.30 p.m.
April 14	CSK vs. KKR	Chennai	7.30 p.m.
April 15	RCB vs. LSG	Bengaluru	7.30 p.m.
April 16	MI vs. PBKS	Mumbai	7.30 p.m.
April 17	GT vs. KKR	Ahmedabad	7.30 p.m.
April 18	RCB vs. DC	Bengaluru	3.30 p.m.
April 18	SRH vs. CSK	Hyderabad	7.30 p.m.
April 19	KKR vs. RR	Kolkata	3.30 p.m.
April 19	PBKS vs. LSG	New Chandigarh	7.30 p.m.



Tough luck: Ayush suffered a straight-game loss. BWF

Ayush falls at the final hurdle

BADMINTON
Press Trust of India
NINGBO (CHINA)

India's Ayush Shetty signed off with a silver medal after his giant-killing run ended in a straight-game loss to world No. 2 Shi Yu Qi in the final of the Badminton Asia Championships here on Sunday.
The 20-year-old from Mangaluru struggled to find his rhythm, going down 8-21, 10-21 to the reigning world champion from China, as India's 61-

year wait for a men's singles gold at the event continued.
Despite the loss, it was a creditable campaign from the unseeded youngster, who became only the second Indian men's singles player after Dinesh Khanna to reach the final of the continental showpiece.
Dinesh remains the only Indian singles champion at the event, having won the title in 1965. Since then, only the men's doubles pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty have lifted the trophy, triumphing in 2023.

City turns on the magic in second half blitz to blow away Chelsea

EURO LEAGUES
Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Manchester City ignited the Premier League title race with a second-half blitz that sealed a 3-0 win against Chelsea as it closed the gap on leader Arsenal on Sunday.
Pep Guardiola's side produced a devastating spell immediately after half-time, with Nico O'Reilly and Marc Guehi scoring in the space of six minutes at Stamford Bridge.
Jeremy Doku wrapped up a statement victory to ensure City took advantage of Arsenal's shock 2-1 home defeat against Bournemouth on Saturday.
Second-placed City is now only six points behind Arsenal with a game in hand, setting up a seismic showdown against the Gunners at the Etihad Stadium on April 19.
Napoli's Serie A title defence suffered a blow with



No sweat: Guehi caps off a smart turn with a composed finish for City's second against Chelsea. REUTERS

Sunday's 1-1 draw at Parma. Scott McTominay's drilled finish on the hour mark gave Napoli a draw which may not be enough for the champion to claim a third Scudetto in four seasons.
Earlier on Saturday, AC Milan relinquished any remaining hope of winning the title after falling to a shock 3-0 home defeat by Udinese.
The results: Premier League: Crystal Palace 2 (Mateta 80, 90+4-pen) bt Newcastle 1 (Osula 43); Nottingham Forest 1 (Williams 38) drew with Aston Villa 1 (Murillo 23-og); Sunderland 1 (Mukiele 61) bt Tottenham 0; Chelsea 0 lost to Manchester City 3 (O'Reilly 51, Guehi 57, Doku 68).
Serie A: Genoa 2 (Malinovskyi 18, Ekuban 84) bt Sassuolo 1 (Kone 57); Parma 1 (Strefezza 1) drew with Napoli 1 (McTominay 60).
Bundesliga: Stuttgart 4 (Stiller 22, Fuehrich 32, Mittelstaedt 56, El Khannouss 86) bt Hamburg 0.
On Saturday: LaLiga: Sevilla 2 (Adams 10-pen, Gudelji 45+2) bt Atletico Madrid 1 (Bonar 35).
Serie A: Atalanta 0 lost to Juventus 1 (Boga 48); AC Milan 0 lost to Udinese 3 (Bartasaghi 27-og, Ekkelenkamp 37, Atta 71).

Determined Bagan overcomes Punjab's challenge in thriller

ISL
Amitabha Das Sharma
KOLKATA

Mohun Bagan Super Giant produced a spectacular late comeback to defeat Punjab FC 3-2, thanks to an added-time winner, in an exciting ISL-12 fixture here on Sunday.
Punjab struck first in the 12th minute through Daniel Ramirez, who calmly finished from close range after receiving a cross from Mohammad Uvais. Bagan responded strongly and found the equaliser in the 29th as Jamie Maclaren capitalised on a clever assist from Robson Robinho.
In the second half, even as the contest reach a higher tempo, Punjab regained the lead at the hour-mark through Nigerian forward Nsungusi Effiong, who volleyed home a precise delivery from compatriot Bede Osuji. Bagan looked in

trouble as the clock ticked past the 70-minute mark, but head coach Sergio Lobera made crucial changes to the attack.
Substitute Sahal Abdul Samad brought the Kolkata giant back into contention with a superb long-range strike and restored parity in the 73rd minute. The equaliser swung the momentum in Bagan's favour and the host snatched victory in stoppage time when another substitute, Jason Cummings, netted the decisive goal.
The win took Bagan to the second spot with 17 points in eight matches, behind Mumbai City FC (18 points), and kept it firmly in the title race.
The results: At Salt Lake Stadium: Mohun Bagan SG 3 (Jamie Maclaren 29, Sahal Abdul Samad 73, Jason Cummings 90+1) bt Punjab FC 2 (Daniel Ramirez 12, Nsungusi Effiong 60).
At Kishore Bharati Stadium: Inter Kashi 1 (Mohammed Asif 15) bt Mohammedan Sporting 0.



Sinner... No. 1 again. AFP

Sinner wins Monte Carlo Masters title

Agence France-Presse
MONTE CARLO
Jannik Sinner beat Carlos Alcaraz in straight sets to win the Monte Carlo Masters for the first time on Sunday and reclaim the World No.1 ranking from his Spanish rival.
Sinner downed Alcaraz 7-6(5), 6-3 to capture his third ATP 1000 title of the year after completing the "Sunshine Double" last month with victories in Indian Wells and Miami.
He joins Novak Djokovic and Rafael Nadal as only the third player to win four successive ATP 1000 titles.

Zhu beats Vaishali, catches up with the Indian at the top

CANDIDATES CHESS
Sports Bureau

In what was one of the most important games in the Women's Candidates chess tournament, Zhu Jiner defeated sole leader R. Vaishali with black pieces in the 12th round at Pegaia, Cyprus, on Sunday. With the win, Zhu has caught up with her Indian rival at the top of the table.
They both have seven points each, going into the final rest day on Monday. Half-a-point behind them are Bibisara Assaubayeva and Anna Muzychuk, with two rounds remaining.
It was indeed a big setback for Vaishali who had begun the day with a full-point lead over Zhu and Muzychuk.
It was not going to be easy for her against the top-seeded Chinese, who has been the fastest rising star



Key win: Zhu capitalised on Vaishali's error to hand the Indian her second loss. FIDE

in women's chess of late.
Once Vaishali erred with her knight on the 36th move, Zhu took control. Three moves later, the Chennai Grandmaster resigned.
In the open section, Javokhir Sindarov retained his two-point lead after playing out a quick draw with Hikaru Nakamura. He has nine points, two more than second-placed Anish Giri, who missed winning chances against Wei Yi.

The results (12th round): Andrey Espenko (Rus) 4.5 drew with R. Praggnanandhaa 5; Matthias Bluebaum (Ger) 5.5 drew with Fabiano Caruana (USA) 6; Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 9 drew with Hikaru Nakamura (USA) 5.5; Wei Yi (Chn) 5.5 drew with Anish Giri (Ned) 7.
Women: Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 6.5 drew with Aleksandra Goryachkina (Rus) 5.5.
R. Vaishali 7 lost to Zhu Jiner (Chn) 7; Divya Deshmukh 5 lost to Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 5; Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) 6.5 bt Kateryna Lagno (Rus) 5.5.

McIlroy's big lead goes up in smoke, shares the top spot with a surging Young

GOLF
Agence France-Presse
AUGUSTA

Rory McIlroy charged back late after squandering a six-stroke edge to share the lead with Cameron Young after a wild third round at the Masters on Saturday.
A chaotic afternoon at Augusta National saw both men plunk key shots into water on the back nine but finish level atop the leaderboard on 11-under 205 through 54 holes, one stroke ahead of American Sam Burns.
McIlroy, who started the day with a record six-shot lead, carded a one-over 73 while Young roared into contention with a scintillating seven-under 65.
McIlroy birdied the 14th and 15th holes to regain the lead but found the trees off the 17th tee on the way to a



Dazzling: Young got off to a scorching start with birdies on five of the first 10 holes. GETTY IMAGES

bogey and his one-over round. Third-ranked Young got off to a scorching start with birdies on five of the first 10 holes.
He birdied 13 and 14, his drive at the 13th hitting a tree and landing fortuitously in the fairway, then overcame a watery bogey at 15 by curling in a 27-foot

birdie putt at the par-three 16th.
Burns carded a 68 and was one stroke in front of Ireland's Shane Lowry.
Lowry aced the 190-yard par-three sixth hole on his way to a 68 that left him fourth on 207, one stroke ahead of Australian Jason Day and England's

who also found water on his way to shooting 69.
McIlroy made a double bogey at the 11th when his approach sailed left into a pond and after a bogey at par-three 12th, his lead had vanished in Amen Corner.
McIlroy responded with a 19-foot birdie putt at the 14th and drove the green in two at the par-five 15th to set up a tap-in birdie only for a bogey at 17 to drop him back.
Rose went from seven adrift to three back and hopes for a final round like last year when he made 10 birdies.
Top scores (third round): 205: Young 73-67-65, McIlroy 67-65-73. 206: Burns 67-71-68. 207: Lowry 70-69-68. 208: Day 69-71-68, Rose 70-69-69. 209: Haotong 71-69-69, Scheffler 70-74-65. 210: Henley 73-71-66, Reed 69-69-72, Cantlay 77-67-66. 211: Knapp 73-69-69, Morikawa 74-69-68, Griffin 72-69-70.



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I am a first-year Law student preparing for the UPSC. I am clueless about the study material. How do I crack the exam?
K. Elamaran

Dear Elamaran,

THE UPSC CSE exam has three stages: Prelims, Mains and Interview. The Prelims have two papers. General Studies I focuses on History, Polity, Geography, Economy, Environment, Science and Tech, and Current Affairs. The General Studies II, also called CSAT, is a test of comprehension, logical reasoning, basic numeracy and general problem solving. Both papers are MCQ types.

The Mains have nine written papers of which the two language papers are qualifying ones. The others are an essay, four General Studies papers, and two papers on an optional subject.

Finally comes the interview, which assesses your personality, clarity of thought and understanding of current affairs.

Start with the NCERT History, Geography, Economics and Science (Classes 6-12) textbooks for the Prelims. Read newspapers every day to stay updated with current affairs. Look up books such as *Indian Polity* by M. Laxmikanth or *Indian Economy* by Ramesh Singh. For the CSAT, practise past papers to work on the skills required. If you choose Law as your optional subject for the Mains, your coursework will overlap with core topics such as constitution, governance, and judiciary, international relations or public administration.

Start small, focus on consistent work on a daily

Consistency matters

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

and weekly plan. Practise essay writing, answering MCQs, revise current affairs, and make short notes for revision.

My son is in Class 12 (Accountancy with Computer Science). He wants a career in software development, data science, or systems analysis. How can he do this with his current non-Science stream in Class 12? Is there some way to bridge the gap?
Naveen

Dear Naveen,

While a non-Maths Class 12 background does not permanently block a career in software, data science, or systems analysis, it is a challenge in our given academic system.

Most B. Tech programmes Maths require Maths in Class 12. He can consider BCA with a focus on Programming, database management, web development, and software

engineering.

Colleges to consider are Christ University, Bengaluru; Loyola College, Chennai; and Amity University, Noida. Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT) offers B.Tech with bridge courses. Some private universities have foundation semesters in Maths and programming.

Look for five-year Integrated programmes (B.Sc + M.Sc / BCA + MBA / B.Tech + Data Science) that may allow non-Maths students if they complete foundation courses in Maths.

Online courses and certifications on NPTEL (Discrete Mathematics, Probability and Statistics), Khan Academy (Pre-Algebra, Algebra, Probability and Statistics), Coursera/ edX (Foundations for Data Science, Python and Maths, Programming and Logic, Python, C, or C++) can help bridge the gap. He can also practise algorithmic thinking via CodeChef, HackerRank, or

LeetCode.

I cleared my CA Foundation and have been a sales consultant, a tutor at a coaching centre, a clerk in a bank, and an academic counsellor in an edtech company. Now I am preparing for NET-JRF, but have fallen out of the habit of studying. How can I improve my concentration?
Samiksha

Dear Samiksha,

Why do you want a NET-JRF career? Are you opting for teaching and research because of job security, or job satisfaction? Create a vision board of what you want for yourself and keep it on your study table. Awareness is the first step to rebuilding focus. Work on resetting your study mindset.

Start small and build momentum, one day at a time. Use structured study techniques and focus on single tasks. Avoid

multi-tasking while studying (no phone, social media scrolling or doing anything else).

Get enough sleep and a nutritious diet, exercise and some form of self-care.

Track your progress visually on a wall calendar to motivate yourself. Have a friend or an online study group so that you are held accountable for your progress.

Give yourself small rewards for completing a session well and look after your mental health.

I finished Class 12 last year and took a gap year to prepare for the NEET. But now I want to move to Finance. I didn't have Commerce as a subject in school. How do I make the move? Sarthak

You can move into finance without a Commerce background. Many professionals come from Science, Arts, or Engineering, and your background can actually be an advantage, especially for analytics, logical reasoning, and quantitative work.

You can explore areas like Corporate Finance, Banking, Investments, Financial Planning, Risk Management, Financial Modelling, or Fintech. To get started, build a foundation in accounting (balance sheets, P&L, cash flow), financial management (time value of money, ratios), basic economics, and corporate finance concepts. Alongside this, develop skills in Excel and financial modelling.

Use online platforms like Coursera, Udemy, NPTEL, and Investopedia, along with beginner-friendly finance books and YouTube channels, to strengthen your basics. For formal pathways, consider a BBA or B.Com (as a second degree or via lateral entry), or short-term certifications like CFA Level 1, Diploma in Banking and Finance, or

Financial Modelling courses.

At the same time, focus on practical exposure through internships, projects like stock analysis, and skills in analytics (Python/SQL), Excel, and communication. Banking exams like SBI PO or IBPS PO

are also strong entry routes.

With the right skills and consistent effort, transitioning into finance is very achievable.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and

suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

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INBRIEF



Indian women compound archers clinch gold medal

The Indian compound women's team won the gold medal at the Archery World Cup Stage-1 in Puebla, Mexico. In the final, India, comprising V. Jyothi Surekha, Pragati and Madhura Dhamangaonkar, defeated USA, consisting of Olivia Dean, Paige Pearce and Alexis Ruiz, 233-232. However, the Indian duo of Pragati and Ojas Deotale lost to USA's Alexis and Stephan Hansen 154-155 in the mixed team bronze medal contest. India finished with a lone gold medal.

Barwal breaks 48-year-old marathon National record

Sawan Barwal on Sunday broke the 48-year-old marathon National record, the longest standing mark in Indian athletics, at the NN Marathon Rotterdam. Barwal clocked 2h 11m and 58s to finish 20th in the elite marathon race and erase the previous time of 2:12:00 which had stood since 1978 in Shivnath Singh's name.

Aman, Mukul settle for silver; Dinesh wins bronze

Aman Sehrawat (61kg) and Mukul Dahiya (86kg) bagged silver medals, while Dinesh (125kg) claimed a bronze at the Asian wrestling in Bishkek, Kyrgyzstan, on Sunday.

The results: 61kg: Kim Kwang Myong (PRK) bt Aman 13-10; **86kg:** Kamran Ghasempour (IRI) bt Mukul by pin. **Third place: 125kg:** Dinesh bt Arslanbek Turdubekov (Kgz) 12-1.

LIVE TELECAST

IPL: Star Sports 1 & JioHotstar, 7.30 p.m.
Serie A: DAZN, 12.15 a.m. (Tuesday)
LaLiga: FanCode, 12.30 a.m. (Tuesday)

Samson relieved to repay team's faith

The wicketkeeper-batter admits he felt the heat going into the fixture against DC; CSK fans will hope his hundred is just the beginning

IPL-19

S. Dipak Ragav
CHENNAI

When Chennai Super Kings signed Sanju Samson ahead of this IPL in a trade from Rajasthan Royals, it was the culmination of a long-cherished dream for both sides.

Since its inception, CSK has been built around M.S. Dhoni, and the former skipper will continue to be the team's flag-bearer.

But time waits for none, and Dhoni is probably in the final lap of his illustrious career. In Samson, there is one cricketer who comes close to being ready to carry that legacy forward.

For starters, the 31-year-old hails from Vizhinjam in Thiruvananthapuram – a coastal town that is culturally and geographically closer to Chennai.

More importantly, his swashbuckling style of play, while still maintaining a calm demeanour on the field, sits well with the team's ethos.

Naturally, the expectations were sky-high ahead of IPL 2026. After scores of 6, 7 and 9, the Kerala wicketkeeper-batter was feeling the heat going into the fixture against Delhi Capitals.

The franchise, too, had not won a single game and required someone to step up in a significant way.

But the Samson who walked out to the centre on



Back to his best: Samson put on a show against DC at Chepauk. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

Saturday seemed unhurried and in rhythm from the get-go.

He produced a pristine cover drive off the very first ball that fetched him three runs. He, then, executed a fine cut off Auqib Nabi for his maiden boundary of the evening.

There was no looking back as he motored along at a strike rate of around 235 in the PowerPlay.

“However many matches you have won for your country, a couple of failures definitely put doubts in your mind,” Samson told the broadcasters after scoring a match-winning unbeaten 115.

“I just wanted to go back to my basics, believe in myself, and just stick to my scoring patterns.”

Samson played his percentages while maintaining a strike rate of nearly 200 through his stay.

“Several thoughts came

to mind. Should I go harder at the start, or should I change my game plan? But I wanted to stick to what had worked, and luckily, it came off beautifully today.

“As a batsman, you need to come back to timing the ball, just looking at it coming out of the bowler's hand.”

Samson was relieved to repay the management's faith in him. “It really means a lot. The trust they showed me in having the trade, I felt I needed to put on a show and say we are still in the tournament.”

Chepauk's ‘Chetta’ did just that in style. To top it off, the self-avowed Rajinikanth fan celebrated his century by doing the actor's iconic salute from the film *Padayappa* and dedicating it to under-fire coach Stephen Fleming.

The CSK fans will hope this knock is just the trailer of bigger things to come.

Overton makes a big impression with his pace and variations

C. Shyam Sundar
CHENNAI

It is not often that a bowler goes only for 18 runs in his full quota in a T20 game where over 400 runs were amassed. To top it, Jamie Overton scalped four wickets in Chennai Super Kings' first win of IPL 2026 against Delhi Capitals at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium here on Saturday.

The 32-year-old troubled the opposition batters with his pace and reaped the rewards. CSK bowling coach Eric Simons said as much in his interaction with the media after the 23-run win.

“...Jamie's got that sort of pace that he can do it and rattle. I mean, he's rattled everybody with his pace.”

The Englishman struck



A pumped up Overton. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

at regular intervals to derail DC's chase.

Simons was impressed with the manner in which Overton found success by sticking to his strengths after having got his lengths wrong in the team's previous fixture against Royal Challengers Bengaluru.

“The important thing is

that each person finds his way of doing the job in the area where he has to bowl. So he tried something last week which didn't work, but he really went with his strengths tonight, went with the hard lengths. He's always had a good yorker.”

It is not pace alone that's brought Overton the results. Simons said: “he's worked on an off pace delivery. When you're bowling 150 kilometres an hour, and you've got an off pace delivery that's under 120, then it's really effective. So he's done some work on that as well.”

Simons, who said the bowlers executing the plans was crucial, would want the unit to keep churning out disciplined performances going forward and Overton has a big part to play.

SNAPSHOTS

Sarun wins men's long jump gold

National indoor champion Sarun Payasingh won the men's long jump gold with 7.46m at the fourth leg of the Indian Athletics Series in Ranchi on Sunday.

The results (winners only): Men: 100m: Aniket (Mah) 10.60; **200m:** Mahendra Santa (Odi) 21.96. **800m:** Mohd. Mahasin Awal (WB) 1:53.21. **5,000m:** Sandeep Pal (UP). **110m hurdles:** Krishik M. (Rel) 13.72. **400m hurdles:** Shakti Singh (Raj) 51.34. **Long jump:** Sarun Payasingh (Odi) 7.46m. **Javelin:** Uttam (Mah) 74.85m; **High jump:** Sarvesh Kushare (Mah) 2.19m. **Women: 100m:** Mousumi Roy (Odi) 11.83. **200m:** Mousumi Roy (Odi) 24.79. **5,000m:** Bharti (Har) 16: 55.42;



Sivaraj and Kamali.

400m hurdles: Vithya Ramraj (Rly) 57.02. **Long jump:** Ancy Sojan (Navy) 6.45m.

Sivaraj, Kamali crowned National surfing champions

Tamil Nadu surfer Sivaraj Babu and Kamali Moorthy were crowned National champions at the Little Andaman Pro 2026 on Sunday.

Sivaraj clinched the men's

title with a score of 13.63, edging past D. Srikanth in the final.

Kamali dominated the women's event, scoring 15.83 to retain her crown. In the SUP Sprint events, Sekar Pachai (1:22.32s) won the men's race, while Vijayalakshmi Irulappan (1:40.35) topped the women's category.

Tree Sports CA's summer camp

The Tree Sports CA will conduct its summer camp for under-12, u-14, and u-16 age groups from April 14 to May 31 at the Loyola College A-ground. For registration, contact 99403 76344.

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N. Sudarshan

For most tennis players, a period like Iga Swiatek’s last nine months will be a resounding success. The Pole won her maiden Wimbledon, the worthiest trophy the sport has to offer, clinched a WTA 1000 title in Cincinnati and bagged a WTA 500 crown in Seoul. Wimbledon was her first title of any kind in over 12 months, and from a ranking of No. 8 just before the title run at the All England Club, she zoomed up to No. 2 in the world, a position she held until early last month.

‘Worst nightmare’

But Swiatek, herself, doesn’t believe this is enough. After an opening round reverse to compatriot and the then World No. 50 Magda Linette in Miami in March, a result the six-time Major champion called “the worst nightmare”, she decided to split with coach Wim Fissette, who was with her when the 24-year-old achieved all of the above results.

Fissette, who had had stints with Grand Slam winners such as Kim Clijsters, Simona Halep, Victoria Azarenka, Angelique Kerber and Naomi Osaka, had joined forces with Swiatek in October 2024, and helped her navigate a reputation-hurting, month-long suspension later that year for a positive dope test.

But none of this seemed to matter, and Swiatek, who will begin her beloved clay-court season at the Porsche Tennis Grand Prix in Stuttgart this week, has announced that she is pairing up with Francisco Roig, a long-time coach of Rafael Nadal, and someone who was part of the Spanish legend’s team for 18 years and all of his 22 Major singles titles.

So what explains Swiatek’s quandary? For one, she did not believe that the results were there to prove that the partnership with Fissette was working. Though she secured three titles last year, reached another final and climbed her way back up the rankings, the successes were concentrated in a narrow three-month window from late-June to late-September.

In seven individual competitions after the trophy-winning achievement in Seoul, Swiatek has not progressed past the quarterfinal. She has lost seven of her last eight matches against top-10 opponents, and two of her three most-recent defeats have come against those ranked 50 or below – Linette, and Maria Sakkari (No. 52) in Doha. The Linette loss was her first in the opening round since the 2021 WTA Finals. Together with the disappointment at Indian Wells, it was also the third time in the last five months that she had conceded back-to-back matches, and this too last happened at the same WTA Finals.

The trigger

“During the tournament in Doha, I realised that I didn’t feel as good on the court as before,” Swiatek told Polish media house *Sport.pl*. “Of course, at different tournaments, there can be various reasons for poor form, but I had the impression that I wasn’t playing that well, and started to lose confidence.

“After the loss to Sakkari, we sat down and talked for a long time. We wondered what to change and how to approach the following week so that I could get back to my solid game. And indeed, before Indian Wells, we took some steps forward. But when I took everything into account, I concluded that I needed a change.”

The use of the words “solid game” was intriguing. When she first burst onto the scene in 2020 by winning her maiden French Open as a teenager, Swiatek was a quintessential counter-puncher, sporting a top-spin heavy game and blessed with supreme athleticism.

Then, from 2022 to 2024 under coach Tomasz Wiktorowski, she infused significant amounts of no-holds-barred baseline aggression into her tennis as she amassed four Slams and spent 125 weeks as World No. 1 – the seventh best run in women’s tennis history and the most among active players.

Aggression for Swiatek is not similar to the flat power that someone like Elena Rybakina hits with but closer to the ‘Nadalesque’ way of risk-taking and bravery shown in attacking the lines. The best reflection of this came in 2022, when she went on a 37-match winning streak – still the best this century – and lifted two Majors.

In fact, in the 76 matches she played that year, she won 22 sets by a 6-0 margin and 20 by 6-1. She was named the WTA Player of the Year in 2022, and bagged the honour again a year later.

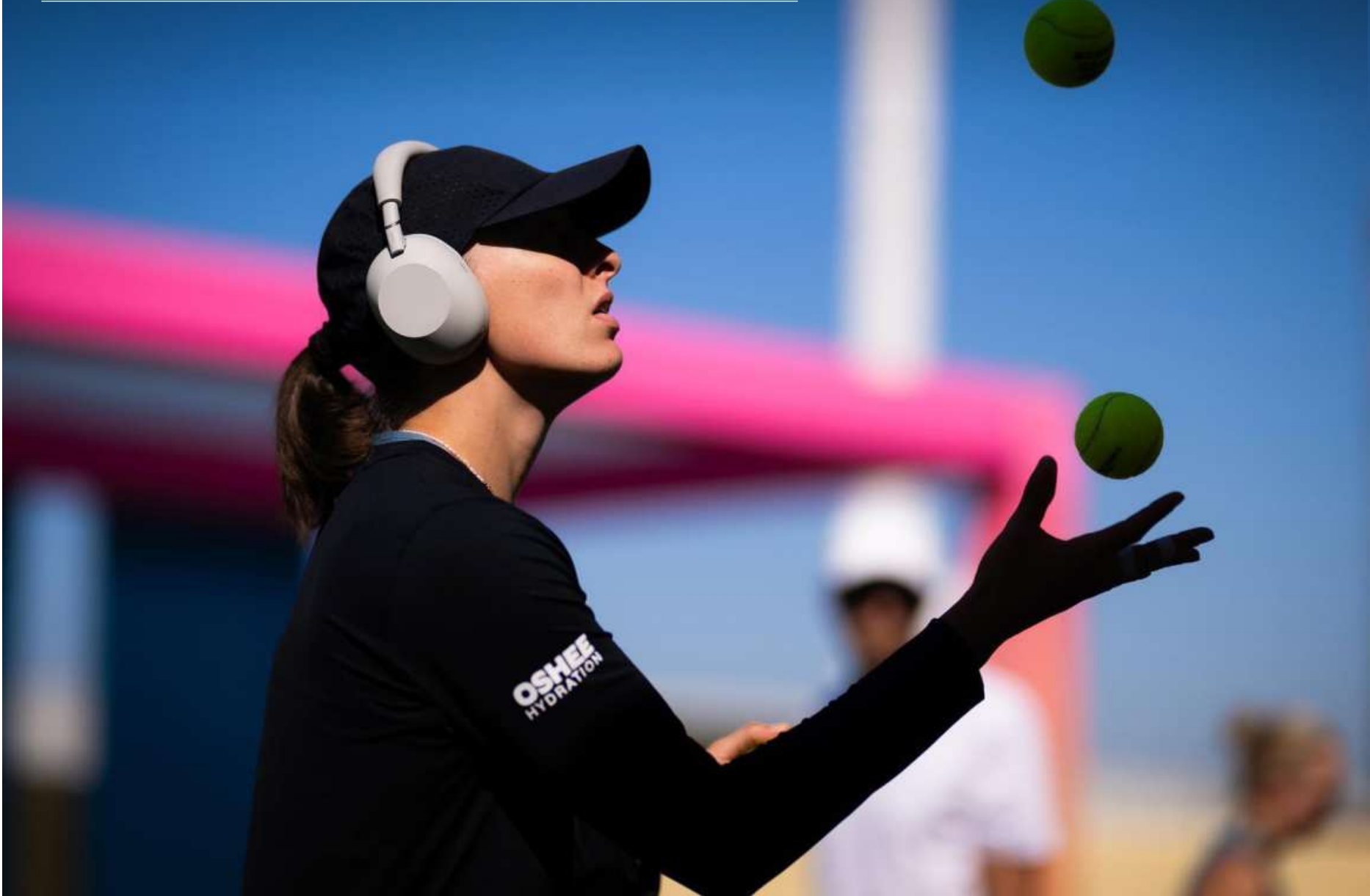
But this style also had a downside to it. When a ground-stroke broke down, match-situation tightened and she was boxed into a corner, Swiatek’s solution to break out of jail was to become more aggressive.

While champions often swear by this attitude, it is not a prudent choice when errors pile up and the need of the hour is a reset.

Nowhere is this reflected better than in her match-up against the two-time Slam winner from America Coco Gauff,

Iga Swiatek and her quest for solidity

The Polish World No. 4 is this era’s leading light, with her six Major titles the most among active women playing full time. But of late, her game has come under a cloud following a series of bad losses. Will the upcoming clay season – her most cherished months in the calendar – spark a turnaround?



GETTY IMAGES



I want to feel like a wall on the court again – making no mistakes and forcing my opponents to make them. I feel that tennis gives me the most pleasure when I am solid

who counts as her strengths some remarkable retrieving ability and propensity to extend rallies. Swiatek won 11 of their first 12 meetings, but has lost all four since then, and all of them in straight sets.

Under Fissette, she attempted to temper her play a bit, seeking to add variety and patience, and tried unlocking different dimensions.

The first signs of this working came at the 2025 Australian Open when she came within a point of making her first-ever final in Melbourne before losing a tight three-setter to eventual winner Madison Keys. “I feel like the ball is listening to me,” she said during the tournament.

Finding full expression

The summer of 2025 was when her partnership with Fissette found full expression as she won Wimbledon, thrashing Amanda Anisimova 6-0, 6-0 in a 57-minute final – a glorious display of controlled aggression and tactical nous.

At one point during the fortnight she even said: “You can still raise your intensity and be patient, and make smart decisions. It just means that you’re going

to play these shots really 100%. But it doesn’t mean that they need to be like crazy.”

The current predicament for Swiatek is that this makeover has started fraying and she is unable to decide which facets in her evolution as a player are worth keeping and which are to be tweaked or shunned altogether.

After Miami, she said she was “confused” and that tennis felt “complicated”. That perhaps explains her desire to get back to the solid variety.

“I want to feel like a wall on the court again – making no mistakes and forcing my opponents to make them,” she elaborated to *Sport.pl*. “I’ve always had that. It was my advantage and I exerted pressure on the court, and it gave me the upper hand.

“I feel that tennis gives me the most pleasure when I am solid. When I’m not, I take unnecessary risks and make many more errors. I want to return to that solidity. I’d like to have more variety in my game, and sometimes use what I do in training during matches – to have the courage to make those decisions. But for now, I’m focusing mainly on the first part: hard work and building solidity.”

Swiatek has trusted Spaniard Roig, in pic, for this task, and his body of work suggests – at least on paper – that he may be the right person.

“The ideal coach should have an ‘eye’ for the game and an intuition of what the player needs, both in the short- and long-term,” Swiatek said recently. “[The coach] should make the right decisions as to when to introduce new shots, when

to start changes in the game, and when to build the game on the player’s strengths.”

Ring-side view

Roig had a ring-side view for the entirety of Nadal’s career, and has both seen – and aided – the legend’s evolution from a clay-court expert to an all-surface master. Swiatek famously idolises Nadal, and her favourite surface is clay, as seen from the fact that four of her six Majors are on the Parisian red dirt. But her triumphs at the 2022 US Open and 2025 Wimbledon show that she has space to grow.

Locked in two of the greatest rivalries with Roger Federer and Novak Djokovic, Nadal developed a style that was offensive and at the same time firm. Roig, alongside Nadal’s uncle Toni and former World No. 1 Carlos Moya, is said to have had a big hand in the 14-time Roland-Garros winner consistently staying ahead of the curve.

This aspect will be important, for women’s tennis is no longer in a state of flux, and is fast developing consistent rivalries.

Aryna Sabalenka has been the world’s best since October 21, 2024 – the day Swiatek relinquished the top spot – and the four-time Slam winner from Belarus has reached the semifinals or better in 12 of her previous 13 Major appearances.

Gauff and Rybakina have both shed the tag of one-Slam wonders by securing the 2025 French Open and 2026 Australian Open respectively.

Statistically, Swiatek sits above all of them. The time has come to show why.

THE GIST



In seven of her most recent individual competitions, Swiatek has not progressed past the quarterfinal. She has also lost seven of her last eight matches against top-10 opponents, and two of her three most-recent defeats have come against those ranked 50 or below



From a counter-puncher to an all-out aggressor to her recent avatar of a calculated attacker, the Pole has undergone continuous transformation. Her quandary now lies in deciding which facets of her evolution are worth keeping and which are to be tweaked or shunned altogether



The 24-year-old has now hired Francisco Roig as her coach. The Spaniard was part of Rafael Nadal’s team for 18 years and all of his 22 Major singles titles, and had a ring-side view of the legend’s journey from a clay-court expert to an all-surface master

Study unravels why men experience more skin infections than women

Hormones may do more than regulate mood, behaviour, and reproduction – and new findings suggest they may also determine how vulnerable we are to skin infections and how we fight them; male sex hormones, which include testosterone, help bacteria communicate and cause skin infections by activating a bacterial signalling system

Kavi Bharathi R.

Men experience more skin infections than women – doctors have known this for a while. They have proposed both behavioural and physiological reasons for this difference but the exact mechanism has been unclear.

Recently, scientists at UT Southwestern Medical Centre in Texas in the U.S. reported that the male sex hormones, androgens, which include testosterone, help bacteria communicate and cause skin infections by activating a bacterial signalling system called quorum sensing.

Their findings, published in *Nature Microbiology*, show that reducing testosterone levels in mouse models increased the animals’ resistance to infections. When the researchers applied testosterone topically to female mice, the infection became more severe.

Skin’s hormones

Sex hormones are generally thought to be produced by the testes or ovaries. However, Tamia Harris-Tryon, Associate Professor of dermatology and immunology at UT Southwestern, and her team had previously shown using an advanced technique called liquid chromatography tandem mass spectrometry that the skin also generates and secretes extremely small concentrations of these hormones.

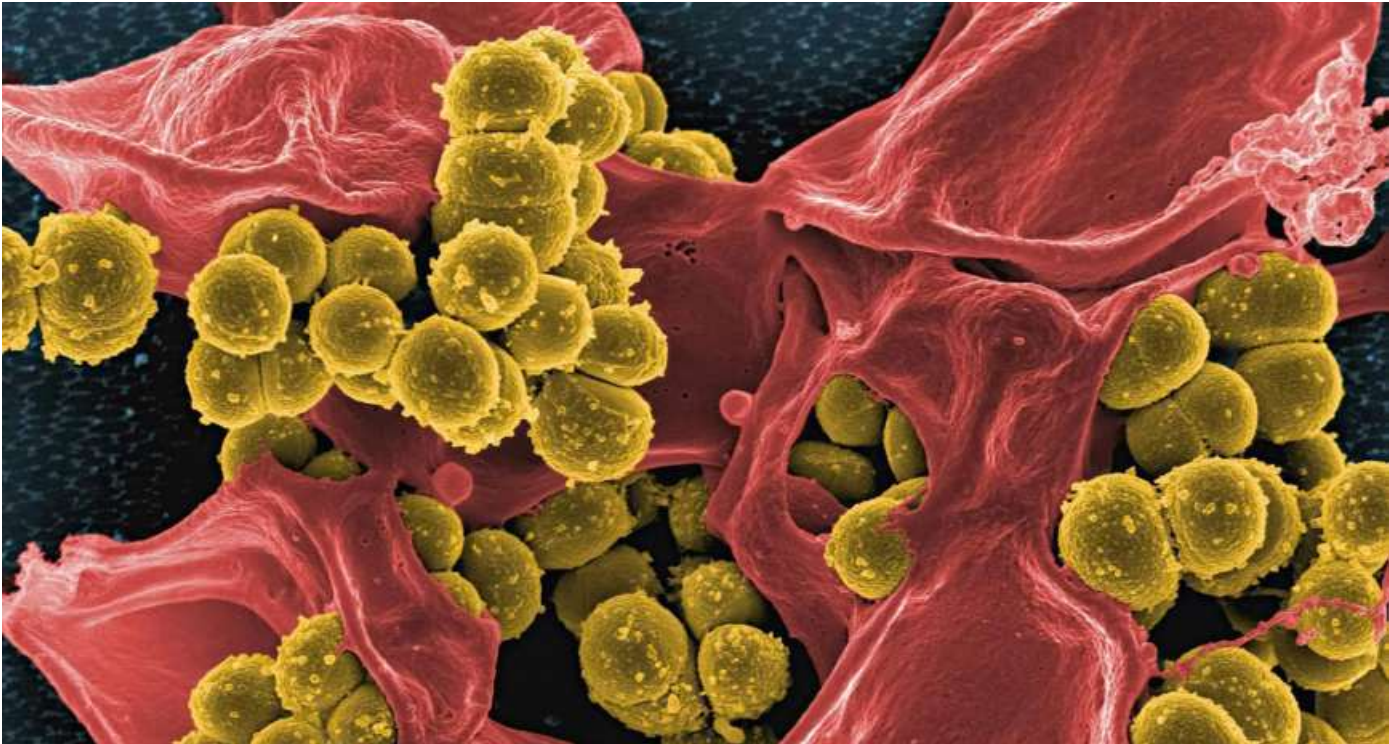
“We continue to be fascinated by how the skin makes sex hormones and how this changes in skin diseases,” Dr. Harris-Tryon said.

The skin is a hormonally responsive organ. Its sebaceous glands can produce hormones, making testosterone readily available to microbes living on the skin’s surface. This is relevant to bacteria like *Staphylococcus aureus*. They don’t begin an infection right away. Instead, they wait and multiply, and activate their disease-causing machinery only once the colony is dense enough to have a fighting chance. Bioinformatic analysis further revealed that the bacteria also respond to the host’s hormones.

“Together, these observations led the team to explore a potential connection between host hormonal changes and microbial dynamics on the skin,” Maria Sindhura John, the study’s first author and a postdoctoral researcher at UT Southwestern, said.

To test whether testosterone from the skin drives infection, the researchers engineered mice that were unable to produce testosterone in the skin. These animals had markedly less severe infections and less skin barrier damage compared to normal mice. When testosterone was applied to hormone-deficient female mice, the infection became more severe.

The effect was specific to androgens. Female sex hormones, oestradiol and progesterone, didn’t affect the bacteria’s quorum sensing – where bacteria release



A coloured scanning electron micrograph of methicillin-resistant *Staphylococcus aureus* (MRSA) bacteria, shown in gold, interacting with a human neutrophil, in red. NIAID

chemical signals into their environment and as the bacterial population grows, the concentration of these signals rises.

“This elegant study shows that host-derived androgen hormones modulate the quorum sensing system to make the bacteria more virulent,” Ferric C. Fang, a clinician scientist at the University of Washington School of Medicine, who wasn’t involved in the study, said. “Thus, the bacteria not only talk to each other, but the host also talks to the bacteria. This may help to explain why men are more susceptible to staphylococcal skin infections than women and could lead to new approaches for the treatment or prevention of these infections.”

Beyond antibiotics

S. aureus is the leading cause of skin infections worldwide. It commonly colonises the skin and nose but when it enters the bloodstream, it can cause septicaemia, a life-threatening condition that could lead to organ failure.

These infections have been increasingly harder to treat, thanks to the rise of multi-drug-resistant *S. aureus*, a strain that resists methicillin and other related antibiotics. Doctors have associated it with prolonged hospital stays and higher mortality.

Conventional antibiotics try to kill bacteria or inhibit their growth, which creates strong evolutionary pressures that encourage bacteria to develop resistance to antibiotics. However, the new study targeted quorum sensing, which disrupts the bacteria’s ability to coordinate harmful behaviours without necessarily threatening their survival.

“This also reduces selective pressure for resistance and may preserve beneficial



The bacteria not only talk to each other, but the host also talks to the bacteria. This may help to explain why men are more susceptible to staphylococcal skin infections than women

FERRIC C. FANG
Clinician scientist at the University of Washington School of Medicine

microbes, making it a potentially more sustainable strategy in combating antimicrobial resistance,” Dr. Sindhura John said.

The researchers identified a mirror-image form of testosterone called enantiomer-testosterone (*ent-T*). While testosterone activated quorum sensing, *ent-T* blocked the bacterial communication pathway and reduced toxicity in human skin cells, red blood cells, and neutrophils in laboratory experiments. Computational modelling revealed how *ent-T* interacted with the bacterial targets, pointing to a possible strategy to tackle antibiotic resistance.

“This was an unexpected but exciting discovery,” Dr. Sindhura John said.

‘Imagine someone is angry’

While studying how bacteria respond to natural testosterone and exploring structurally similar molecules to understand the specificity of the response, they found bacteria could distinguish between subtle molecular differences. This opened a new avenue to design compounds that can deliberately switch off harmful bacterial behaviour.

“Imagine if someone is angry – you

don’t remove or kill the person,” Dr. Sindhura John said. “Rather, you calm them down so they behave normally again. We are doing something similar with bacteria.”

Similarly, *S. aureus* is usually a normal skin resident but it becomes harmful when its environment changes. Instead of killing it, the researchers want to suppress its virulence and restore it to a harmless state. “This way, we reduce antibiotic resistance and maintain skin balance,” Dr. Sindhura John added.

The interaction between humans and the resident bacteria is complex and poorly understood. “This study provides an interesting new angle, with the potential for exploitation to reveal new ways to combat important human infections,” Simon J. Foster, the West Riding Chair in microbiology at the University of Sheffield, said.

Early phase trials

The researchers aim to test these findings in human skin models and move to early-phase trials to assess safety and efficacy. They are also keen to understand how these mechanisms operate within the complexity of the human microbiome.

“If successful, this approach could represent a paradigm shift in how we treat infections – moving away from broadly killing bacteria toward more precise modulation of their behaviour,” Dr. Sindhura John said.

This approach could lead to therapies that are more effective, less disruptive to the body’s natural microbiome, and less likely to drive antibiotic resistance.

(Kavi Bharathi R. is a science writer based at the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru.bharathi.colors@gmail.com)

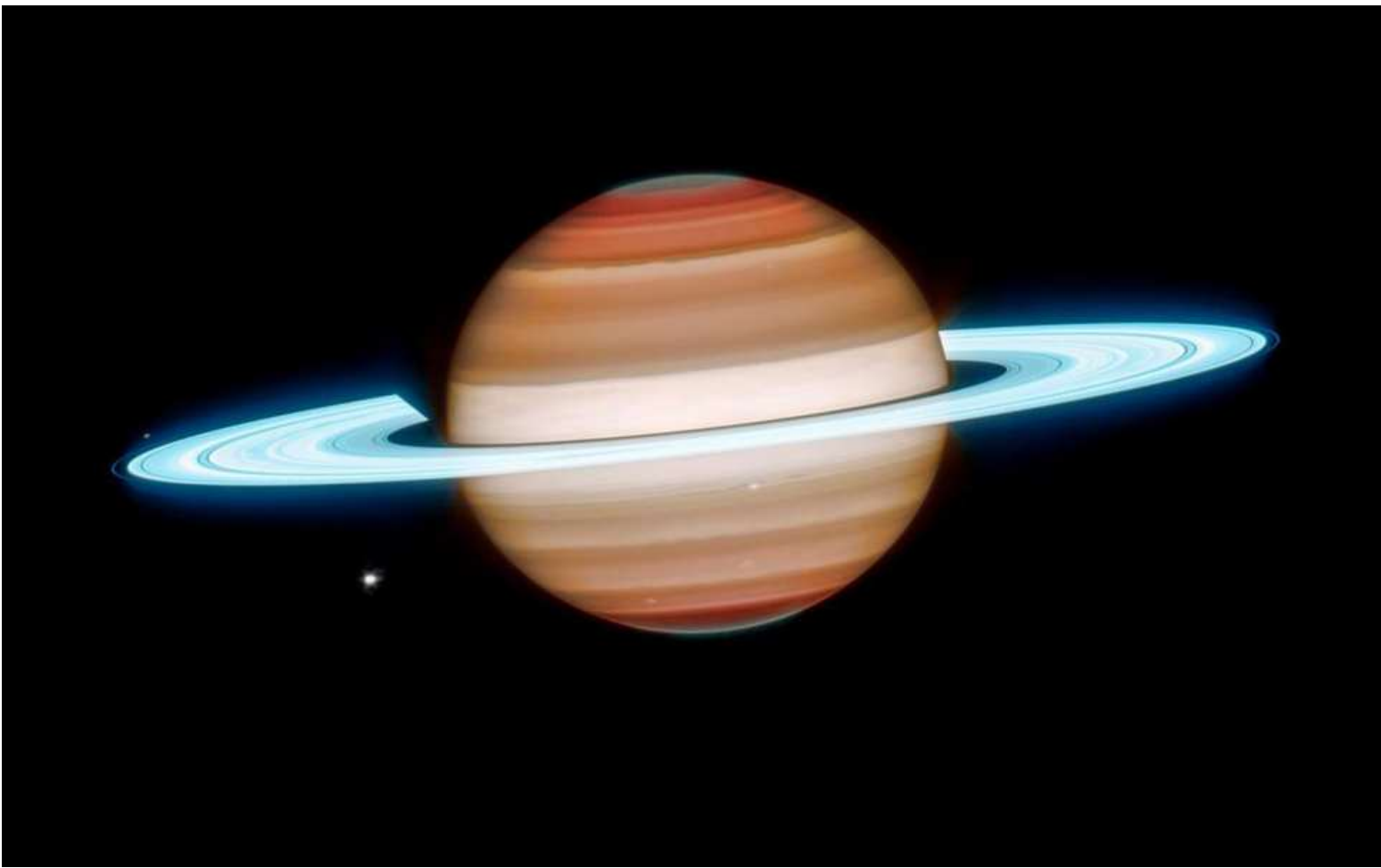
THE GIST

▼ Skin’s sebaceous glands can produce hormones, making testosterone readily available to microbes living on the skin’s surface. This is relevant to bacteria like *Staphylococcus aureus*

▼ *S. aureus* is the leading cause of skin infections worldwide. It commonly colonises the skin and nose but when it enters the bloodstream, it can cause septicaemia, a life-threatening condition

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BIG SHOT



In March, the Webb and Hubble space telescopes teamed up to observe Saturn and acquire a richer understanding of its atmosphere. This image shows Webb’s view. The rings are bright because they are made of water ice, which is very reflective. The image also highlights the jet stream called the ribbon wave across the northern mid-latitudes. NASA

QUESTION CORNER

Nature’s signals



Q: What are sentinel species?

A: A sentinel species is a species whose members’ health signals the condition of the ecosystem in which they

live. Scientists monitor them because they are among the first to respond to stressors in their environment, such as pollution and disease, and their response also tends to be more apparent than most other species.

In other words, they can provide early warnings of ecosystem decline.

Sentinel species tend to occupy a fixed territory and live long enough to accumulate toxins. They also have physiologies that amplify the effects of environmental change. Thus, when something goes wrong in their habitat, they show it first.

The most common example is frogs. Their skin is permeable and absorbs whatever enters the water or soil around them, making them very sensitive to pesticides and pathogens. A declining frog population has often been a sign of wider ecological stress, even before other indicators detect the problem.

Canaries in coal mines worked on the same principle: the bird’s faster metabolism made it succumb to carbon monoxide before human miners could



The IUCN declared the emperor penguin to be an endangered species on April 9. AFP

notice anything. Researchers also use honeybees to track agricultural chemical loads, polar bears to monitor Arctic contaminant accumulation, and certain fish species to detect industrial runoff.

On April 9, the International Union for Conservation of Nature declared the emperor penguin to be an endangered species. Emperor penguins are sentinel species for warming in the Antarctic region. Climate change is projected to halve their population by the 2080s.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Percentage increase in gross GST collection in February

8.1 % increase in gross GST collection sees revenue reach ₹1.83 lakh crore in February. Higher growth in revenues from imports and improved domestic sales lead the drive. Gross domestic revenue rose 5.3% to about ₹1.36 lakh crore, while gross import revenue climbed 17.2% to ₹47,837 crore. Refunds rose 10.2% at ₹22,595 crore. PTI

Number of flights to West Asia cancelled by Pakistan due to war

184 international flights from Pakistan to West Asia have been cancelled since Saturday owing to the escalating situation after the U.S. and Israel attacked Iran. Flight services in the region have been disrupted or suspended after the closure of the Dubai and Abu Dhabi airports which serve as a major hub for connecting flights to Europe, U.S., South America. PTI

Worth of projects inaugurated by Prime Minister in Madurai

4,400 crore-worth projects were inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday. He laid foundation for four-laning of Marakkanam–Puducherry and Paramakudi–Ramanathapuram of key NH routes. He inaugurated eight redeveloped railway stations in Tamil Nadu and the Chennai Beach–Egmore 4th Line. PTI

Number of calls received by special helpdesk in Kerala

381 calls have been received so far by the 24-hour special helpdesk set up by NORKA Roots, after the Israel–Iran conflict. It was established to assist Non-Resident Keralites (NRKs) and their families amid escalating tensions in the region. Of the total calls received, 137 were from abroad and 244 from within the country, the Chief Minister's Office said in a statement. PTI

Number of people killed in a blast at Nagpur factory

17 people were killed and 18 others injured in a blast at a mining and industrial explosives manufacturing factory in Maharashtra's Nagpur district on Sunday. The incident comes a day after a blast at a cracker unit in Andhra Pradesh's Kakinada district claimed 21 lives. The blast took place at the SBL Energy Limited factory, at Raulgaon in Katol tehsil, Nagpur district. PTI

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Between 14 years and the gallows

The Sattankulam trial judge accepted the Sriharan bar in his sentencing order and was forced to the rope; even ordinary life imprisonment, the judge wrote, would let the convicts come out in fourteen years through determined effort

LETTER AND SPIRIT

V. Venkatesan

On April 6, the Madurai trial court in *Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) v Sridhar* sentenced nine suspended policemen to death. They had killed P. Jayaraj and his son J. Bennix in police custody in June 2020. Judge G. Muthukumaran's reasoning is being celebrated as judicial intolerance of uniformed brutality. It is also worth reading as a confession. The case fell within the rarest of rare, he wrote, in terms that left no room for life imprisonment

The doctrine he was applying comes from *Bachan Singh v State of Punjab* (1980). There a Constitution Bench held that the death sentence may be imposed only in the rarest of rare cases when the “alternative option of life imprisonment is unquestionably foreclosed”. The Sattankulam judge believed it was foreclosed. The trial court had only two options. It could send the convicts away for life. Or it could send them to the gallows. What it could not do was occupy the middle ground constitutional courts have fashioned since 2008. That ground is a life sentence quantified in years, twenty or thirty or forty, served without remission. The intermediate sentence has become a fixture of Indian capital jurisprudence. It remains off-limits to the trial courts themselves.

The doctrinal source is the 3:2 majority of the Constitution Bench in *Union of India v V. Sriharan @ Murugan* in December 2015. The majority built on *Swamy Shraddananda v State of Karnataka* (2008). It held that only the High Courts and the Supreme Court could commute death to a fixed-term life sentence beyond statutory remission. Sessions courts, the bench ruled, could not invent a special category of sentencing. The principle has since been reaffirmed in *Kiran v State of Karnataka*



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

(2025) and applied in *Sukhdev Yadav v State (NCT of Delhi)* (2025).

The Sattankulam trial judge accepted the bar in his own sentencing order. He cited the December 2025 *Kiran* ruling which held that Sessions Courts cannot bridge “the hiatus between 14 years and death”. In paragraph 323 of his order, Judge Muthukumaran recorded that the Sessions Court has no power to impose imprisonment for life until death. The defence for the fourth accused had pleaded the same limitation, citing the same authority.

Limitations on Trial Courts

The justification offered in *Sriharan* is surprisingly thin. The majority called the special category an inherent power of constitutional courts, unavailable to trial courts. Yet trial courts already wield the most consequential sentencing power the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) recognises. If they can extinguish life under *Bachan Singh*, why may they not impose the lesser sentence of life without remission?

The Supreme Court has acknowledged

the trap. In *Kiran*, the Bench described Shraddananda's concern: ordinary life imprisonment amounts to fourteen years with remission, leaving a gap that grave crimes outstrip. The special category was devised to bridge the hiatus. *Sriharan* then withheld the bridge from the trial courts most likely to need it.

The consequence in Sattankulam is plain. Even ordinary life imprisonment, the judge wrote, would let the convicts come out in fourteen years through determined effort. Section 433A of the CrPC fixed that minimum. He found the interval derisory for the brutality before him. *Sriharan* denied him the calibrated alternative. He could not direct, say, thirty years of actual incarceration without remission, a sentence second only to death. He could only choose between a sentence he considered inadequate and the rope. He chose the rope.

The defenders of *Sriharan* must be heard. Uniformity, they argue, requires the special category to remain with constitutional courts, lest sessions judges impose idiosyncratic non-remittable terms. They invoke appellate scrutiny in

death references as the only safeguard. Trial courts also impose death sentences, subject to confirmation under Section 366 of the Code. Uniformity is achieved through appellate correction, not through pre-emptive denial of jurisdiction.

A sharper critique is empirical. The Square Circle Clinic at NALSAR released its Annual Statistics Report on the death penalty in February. Its findings cut against any easy reading of the Sattankulam result. In *Manoj v State of Madhya Pradesh* (2022), the Supreme Court directed trial courts to gather information about the prisoner's background, mental health and prison conduct before imposing a death sentence. These guidelines are routinely ignored. *Vasanta Sampat Dupare* (2025) elevated compliance with *Manoj* to a fair trial right under Article 21, without changing trial court practice.

At the same time, the special category *Shraddananda* devised has become the rule rather than the exception at the appellate level. All five Supreme Court commutations in 2025 went to whole-life without remission.

The Sattankulam verdict will travel to the Madras High Court on confirmation. The Madurai Bench has followed this case since taking *suo motu* cognisance in June 2020. It will have the option *Sriharan* denied the trial judge. It may convert the sentences into fixed-term life imprisonment without remission. That outcome would expose the contradiction. A special category trial courts cannot use is becoming the default above them.

According to the Square Circle Clinic's report, most trial courts impose death sentences without the mitigation hearings *Manoj* demands. The Sattankulam judge did hold them, and the architecture failed him anyway. Extending the special category of fixed-term sentencing to him would appear to remedy one rung of a broken ladder. Yet reconsideration of the post-*Bachan Singh* edifice would still be overdue.

(The author is a journalist and legal researcher.)

THE GIST

▼ The death sentences for the Sattankulam custodial killings highlight a conflict between the “rarest of rare” doctrine and legal restrictions, with the trial judge choosing the death penalty over an inadequate life sentence because judicial precedents barred them from imposing a fixed-term, non-remittable sentence.

▼ Critics argue this outcome highlights a “broken ladder” in Indian jurisprudence, where the Supreme Court's *Sriharan* decision forces trial courts into binary sentencing (death or ‘14-year jail’) by withholding the “middle ground” of long-term imprisonment, a tool now default at the appellate level.

Are biomass stoves a cleaner, cheaper alternative to LPG?

Can modern cookstoves turn the return of firewood into a sustainable alternative during the LPG crisis?

Ankit Mathur

The story so far:

Owing to the LPG crisis, many areas—especially rural regions—have reported going back to firewood that are generally seen as increasing drudgery for women, while also causing pollution and health hazards.

Are today's firewood-based stoves less polluting and benign to human use?

Modern biomass stoves, often called improved cookstoves (ICS), represent a major step up from traditional cooking methods. Unlike old-fashioned mud stoves, they can cut fuel use by up to two-thirds while dramatically reducing smoke.

Traditional “chulhas” waste most of their heat through poor airflow and have an efficiency of barely 10%. By contrast, modern stoves reach thermal efficiency levels of 38% to 45%. Technologies such

as secondary aeration help to catch soot and harmful gases before they turn into smoke.

How can mass firewood-based cooking be made sustainable?

Cooking with firewood can be sustainable, provided the wood is harvested and used responsibly. Firewood is a renewable resource as long as the rate of extraction does not exceed the rate of regrowth. Since improved cookstoves burn fuel more efficiently, they can reduce the amount of wood needed for a meal.

Modern cookstoves can also run on alternative biomass fuels, including pellets and briquettes made from sawdust or agricultural waste. This widens the fuel base and takes some pressure off raw firewood.

Financing is key to achieving deployment at scale. Emissions savings enabled by improved cookstoves can be tracked and turned into carbon credits,

creating a funding stream that makes stoves more affordable for lower-income families.

What about the cost of equipment and fuel expenses?

Upfront costs vary significantly. Household models start below ₹2,000, while commercial systems can exceed ₹20,000, depending on the manufacturer and purchase channel (whether direct, through e-commerce, or via distributors). For low- and middle-income households, managing upfront costs can be made easier through financing partnerships involving microfinance, CSR programs, and carbon finance.

The principal operating cost is fuel, and modern cookstoves' high thermal efficiency can significantly reduce fuel requirements. Today's stoves have cut firewood consumption by more than 50%.

Firewood is highly cost-effective compared with LPG, especially during the

ongoing supply crunch when commercial LPG rates in major cities have exceeded ₹100/kg. From the wide range of prices available for different firewood types, it is possible to assume a rough average cost of around ₹10/kg (if firewood is being bought instead of being simply scavenged). Considering that 4 kilos of firewood deliver the same cooking energy output as 1 kg of commercial LPG (in an improved cookstove), firewood could potentially offer cost savings of well over 60%.

What supply chain would be needed for mass adoption? Will this be a massive investment?

Adopting biomass cookstoves on a large scale absolutely does not require a massive investment in fuel supply chains. Since the primary fuels - like firewood, crop waste, and dung cakes - are already widely available in rural and semi-urban areas, there is less need for expensive, centralised infrastructure.

Scaling up is therefore more about strengthening distribution networks. Success depends on improving logistics, last-mile delivery, and local partnerships. Just as importantly, building user awareness and providing reliable after-sales support are essential to making sure these stoves remain a permanent part of daily life.

(The author is co-founder and CEO, Greenway Grameen)

THE GIST

▼ Improved Cookstoves (ICS) offer a sustainable solution by increasing thermal efficiency, reducing smoke, and cutting firewood usage by over 50%.

▼ Mass adoption of efficient biomass stoves does not require massive infrastructure investment, as local, renewable fuels (wood, agricultural waste) are readily available.

